

Latin, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

Latin is not learned the way most languages are learned. Nobody is going to greet you in it, and this book will not pretend otherwise — you learn Latin to *read* it, and to find out why so much of the vocabulary you already own looks the way it does.

Latin is a **taproot**: the ancestor of Spanish, French, Italian, and Portuguese, and the single largest source of English’s vocabulary after English’s own Germanic core. Almost every lesson here pays a double dividend — you learn a Latin word *and* you see why a dozen English words, and their Romance cousins, look the way they do.

Latin uses the alphabet you are reading, so there is no script to decode; the work is the words and the **endings**. Latin carries meaning in its endings rather than in word order or helper-words, which is why it can drop pronouns and still be perfectly clear (*agō* already means “I do”). Each chapter introduces that machinery one piece at a time, exactly where a real phrase needs it — never as a front-loaded grammar table.

We use **classical** pronunciation (Caesar’s *v* was a *w*, his *c* always hard) and mark long vowels with a **macron** (*ā ē ī ō ū*), as teaching texts do, though Romans themselves wrote none. Roots are traced back toward Proto-Indo-European where the trail is clear, and forward into English and the Romance languages — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Latin out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it

stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Latin greetings — and why they matter more than most first words. Latin is a **taproot**: these five salutations are the ancestors of the greetings you met in Spanish, Italian, French, and Portuguese, *and* the etymons of a surprising slice of English’s polite vocabulary. Learn *valē* and you have already half-learned *value*, *valid*, and *prevail*. Each lesson introduces the sounds its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/LA-C01-*.md*.

1.1 *salvē* / *salvēte* — “hello” (be well)

Sounds you’ll need

Latin is read as written, every letter sounded. A **macron** (ā, ē, ī, ō, ū) marks a *long* vowel — held longer, never changing its quality. V is like English “way” before a vowel. *salvē* = *SAL-weh*. The classical *v* was a **w**: Romans said *SAL-weh*, not “sal-vay.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Salvē (to one person) / *salvēte* (to several) is the imperative of *salvēre*, “to be in good health,” from *salvus* “safe, sound, whole.” To greet someone in Latin is to *wish them health*. That one root *salvus/salvāre* fans out enormously into English: **save**, **safe**, **salvage**, **salvation**, **salute**, **salubrious**, and the toast “**salut!**” And into the Romance children as the very word for health — Spanish *salud*, Italian *salute*, French *salut* (which became a greeting again, having started as one).

Grammar Lens

Notice *salvē* vs. *salvēte*: Latin changes the *ending* to mark one listener versus many (-*e* singular, -*ete* plural). This is your first taste of the feature that defines Latin — meaning carried in **endings**, not word order or extra words. English lost almost all of this; its Romance grandchildren kept some. You will meet it in every chapter.

1.2 *avē* / *avēte* — “hail” (a formal greeting)**Sounds you’ll need**

Avē = *AH-weh* (again the *w*-sound for *v*). Two syllables, the second long.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Avē is the more ceremonious greeting — “hail” — from *avēre* “to fare well, to be eager.” It survives in English essentially unchanged inside the prayer “**Ave Maria**” (“Hail, Mary”), and stands in the famous salute *avē atque valē* — “hail and farewell” — Catullus’s words at his brother’s grave, pairing the greeting you say on arrival with the one you say on leaving (next lesson).

Why it’s said this way

Avē carried a whiff of rank and ritual — addressed to emperors and gods (*avē, Caesar*). For an everyday “hi,” Romans reached for *salvē*; *avē* was the bow, not the wave.

1.3 *valē* / *valēte* — “goodbye” (be strong)**Sounds you’ll need**

Valē = *WAH-leh*. As with *salvē*, a health-and-strength wish frozen into a command.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Valē (singular) / *valēte* (plural) is the imperative of *valēre*, “to be strong, to be well” — so goodbye in Latin literally wishes you *strength*. The root *valēre* is another English gold mine: **value**, **valid**, **valiant**, **valour**, **valence**, **prevail**, **convalesce**, **ambivalent** (to be “strong both ways”). And the Romance children carry *valēre* as their verb “to be worth” — Spanish *valer*, Italian *valere*, French *valoir*.

Grammar Lens

Three of these greetings — *salvē*, *avē*, *valē* — are the same grammatical shape: a bare **imperative**, a command form of a verb about health or strength. Latin doesn’t say “hello”; it *orders* you to thrive. Feel how the *-ē/-ēte* pair recurs: once you know it, you can address one friend or a whole room.

1.4 *grātiās agō* — “thank you” (I give thanks)

Sounds you’ll need

Grātiās = GRAH-tee-ās; *agō* = AH-go. The *c/t* before *i* are hard in classical Latin — GRA-tee, not “GRA-shee.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

The full phrase is *grātiās tibi agō* — literally “**I give thanks to you**” (*grātiās* “thanks,” *tibi* “to you,” *agō* “I do/drive”). The noun *grātia* means “favour, grace, gratitude,” from *grātus* “pleasing, thankful.” Into English: **grace**, **gratitude**, **gratis**, **grateful**, **gracious**, **ingratiate**, **congratulate**. And straight into the Romance “thank you” you already learned — Italian *grazie*, Spanish *gracias*, Portuguese *graças* — all just the plural *grātiās*, “thanks,” worn smooth by time.

Grammar Lens

Agō means “I do”: the *-ō* ending *is* “I,” so no separate word for the pronoun is needed. This is Latin’s other great habit — the verb ending tells you *who* acts. *Agō* itself is another root you know: **agent**, **act**, **agenda** (“things to be done”), **agile**, **navigate**.

1.5 *ita* / *nōn* — “yes” and “no”

Sounds you’ll need

Ita = *IH-tah*; *nōn* = *nōne*, with a long *ō*.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Here is a surprise: **classical Latin had no plain word for “yes.”** To agree you said *ita* (“thus, so”), *sīc* (“so, in this way”), *certē* (“certainly”), or simply *repeated the verb* — asked “are you coming?” you answered “I’m coming.” It was *sīc* that hardened into the Romance “yes”: Spanish and Italian *sí*, French *si* (the emphatic yes). “No” is easier: *nōn* (“not”), from older *ne-oenum* “not one thing” — the ancient negative *ne-* that also gives English **no**, **not**, **none**, **never**, and which you will meet again as Sanskrit *na*.

1.6 Recap

Latin		Meaning
<i>salvē</i> / <i>salvēte</i>	<i>be well</i>	hello
<i>avē</i> / <i>avēte</i>	<i>fare well</i>	hail (formal)
<i>valē</i> / <i>valēte</i>	<i>be strong</i>	goodbye
<i>grātiās (tibi) agō</i>	<i>I give thanks to you</i>	thank you
<i>ita</i> / <i>nōn</i>	<i>thus / not</i>	yes / no

Latin greets you by *commanding your health*: *salvē* “be well,” *valē* “be strong.” Those two roots alone — *salvus* and *valēre* — seeded *save*, *safe*, *salute*, *salvation* and *value*, *valid*, *valiant*, *prevail*, and became the Romance words for health and worth. This is the whole reason to learn Latin inside this curriculum: it is the root the Spanish, Italian, French, and Portuguese tracks keep pointing back to, and a root of English besides. Next chapter: *quis es?* (“who are you?”), *nōmen mihi est...* (“my name is...”), and the endings that let Latin drop pronouns entirely.

Chapter 2

Numbers One to Ten

2.1 ūnus, duo, trēs, quattuor, quīnque — one to five

You've seen these numbers before — worn down. Here they are new, before a thousand years of erosion set to work.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	Latin	said
1	I	ūnus	<i>OO-nus</i>
2	II	duo	<i>DOO-oh</i>
3	III	trēs	<i>trayss</i>
4	IV	quattuor	<i>KWAT-twor</i>
5	V	quīnque	<i>KWEEN-kwe</i>

The Roman numerals **I II III IV V** are the tally you already half-know from clock faces — one, two, three strokes, then **IV** (one *before* five) and **V** (five itself). (The **qu** in *quattuor/quīnque* is said **kw**, and every Latin **v** is a **w** — so *quīnque* is *KWEEN-kwe*.)

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Latin is the well the Romance tracks keep drawing from. Line these up against their descendants and you see the erosion happen:

Latin	→ French	→ Spanish
<i>ūnus</i>	un	uno
<i>duo</i>	deux	dos
<i>trēs</i>	trois	tres
quattuor	quatre	cuatro
<i>quīnque</i>	cinq	cinco

(A purist’s note: French *deux* and Spanish *dos* actually descend from the **accusative** *duōs*, not the *duo* shown — as Romance words generally do.)

Quattuor → *quatre* → *cuatro* is the same wearing-down the Hindi track shows for *catvāri* → *chār* — two branches of one ancient word (**PIE *k^wetwóres**), one softening in Europe, one in India. And they seed English too: *ūnus* in *unit* and *union*, *duo* in *duo* and *dual*, *trēs* in *trio* and *triple*, *quīnque* in *quintet*.

Grammar Lens: A grammar seed: the first three bend

Here’s something Latin does that its children mostly dropped: **one, two and three change their endings** to match what they count — *ūnus/ūna/ūnum*, *duo/duae*, *trēs/tria* — while **four and up stay fixed**. You don’t need the full tables yet; just notice that *ūnus* is really *ūn-* with a changeable tail, and file away that Latin makes even its numbers agree.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ūnus*, *duo*, *trēs*, *quattuor*, *quīnque*” — remember *v* = *w*, *qu* = *kw*
- the erosion — “*quattuor* → *quatre* → *cuatro*”
- the tally — I, II, III, IV, V

Before you move on

Count to five in Latin. (*Ūnus*, *duo*, *trēs*, *quattuor*, *quīnque*.) Which Latin word is the source of both French *quatre* and Spanish *cuatro*? (**quattuor**.) How is the **qu** in *quīnque* pronounced? (**kw** — *KWEEN-kwe*.) Which of the first five numbers **change their endings** to match what they count? (**One, two, three** — four and up

stay fixed.) Next: six to ten, and the numbers hiding in the calendar.

2.2 sex, septem, octō, novem, decem — six to ten

Four of these five are hiding in your calendar right now — with the wrong numbers on them. Here's why.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	Latin	said
6	VI	sex	<i>sex</i>
7	VII	septem	<i>SEP-tem</i>
8	VIII	octō	<i>OK-toh</i>
9	IX	novem	<i>NO-wem</i>
10	X	decem	<i>DEK-em</i>

The numerals climb by adding to five — **VI VII VIII** (five-and-one, -two, -three) — then **IX** (one *before* ten) and **X**. (Remember *v = w*, so *novem* is *NO-wem*; and *c* is always hard *k*, so *decem* is *DEK-em*.)

You'll want to know: The numbers frozen in the calendar

Say the last four out loud and read the months beside them:

Latin	month	but it's month #
<i>septem</i> (7)	September	9
<i>octō</i> (8)	October	10
<i>novem</i> (9)	November	11
<i>decem</i> (10)	December	12

September literally means “the seventh.” It sits in ninth place because the old Roman year **began in March** — so month one was March, and the seventh month was our September. When January and February were later pushed to the front, the names never moved. Every year you write four Latin numbers, each two places off, because Rome renumbered the calendar and forgot to rename the months.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

- *sex* → **sextet**, **sextant** (and *sex*- “six” in *sexagesimal*, base-60)
- *octō* → **octave**, **October** — while its Greek twin *oktō* gives **octagon** and **octopus** (eight arms)
- *decem* → **decimal**, and — via *duodecim* “twelve” — **dozen** (its Greek cousin *dekás* “group of ten” adds **decade**)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sex, septem, octō, novem, decem” — v = w, c = k
- the calendar — “septem → September, the seventh month... now ninth”
- the tally — VI, VII, VIII, IX, X

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Latin. (*Sex, septem, octō, novem, decem.*) Why does **September** (“the seventh”) fall in the ninth month? (Rome’s year began in **March**; two months were later added at the front and the names never changed.) How is *novem* said, and why? (*NO-wem* — Latin **v** is a **w**.) What everyday base-ten word comes straight from *decem*? (**decimal**.) You can now count to ten in the language every Romance number came from.

Chapter 3

Please

3.1 quaesō — please (I ask)

Latin has no word that simply means “please.” Instead you say what you’re actually doing: **asking**.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

quaesō — said *KWAI-so* (qu = **kw**, ae = **eye**) — literally means “**I ask**” or “**I beg**.” Romans dropped it into a sentence exactly where English drops *please*:

*Dā mihi aquam, **quaesō*** — “Give me water, **please**” (lit. “...I ask”).

It’s a worn-down cousin of the verb **quaerere**, “to seek, to ask” — the same root English took for **query**, **quest**, **question**, **require** and **inquire**. So *quaesō* is, at heart, “I’m seeking [this] of you.”

Why it’s said this way

Because there’s no single word, Latin had a small kit of polite moves — worth meeting so the absence doesn’t feel like a gap:

- **sīs** — a squeezed **sī vīs**, “**if you wish**” (to one person); plural **sultis** (*sī vultis*). This is the *same* “if you wish” strategy French will use in *s’il te plaît*.
- **amābō tē** — literally “**I will love you**” — a warm, coaxing “please,” the way English might say “be a dear.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quaesō” — *KWAI-so*, “I ask”
- in place — “Dā mihi aquam, quaesō”
- the “if you wish” version — “sīs” (from *sī vīs*)

Before you move on

What did Romans literally say instead of “please”? (**quaesō** — “I ask/beg.”) What verb is it from, and which English words share that root? (**quaerere** “to seek” — *query, quest, require*.) What does **sīs** stand for? (*sī vīs*, “if you wish” — the same idea French uses in *s’il te plaît*.)

Chapter 4

Sorry

4.1 ignōsce mihi — “forgive me” / I’m sorry

You’ve met **quaesō**, the worn-down “I ask” Romans used for *please*. Their word for *sorry* is built the very same way — a small verb carrying the whole apology.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

- **ignōsce** — the imperative “**forgive!**,” from **ignōscere**, itself **in-** (here appearing as **ig-**, “not”) + **(g)nōscere**, “**to know.**” Literally, *ignōscere* means “**to not-know**” — i.e. to overlook, to treat as unseen. Asking forgiveness in Latin is asking someone *not to hold something against you*, as if they hadn’t noticed it.
- **mihi** — “**to me,**” the dative pronoun.

So **ignōsce mihi** is “**forgive [it] to me**” — *don’t hold this against me*. That root **(g)nōscere**, “to know,” reaches deep into English: **know** itself traces to the very same ancient root, alongside **recognize** (“know again”), **cognition**, and **notice**. Latin’s word for “sorry” and English’s word for “know” are, at bottom, blood relatives.

Why it’s said this way

Latin also had an **impersonal** construction for plain regret — no imperative, no “you” at all: **paenitet mē**, literally “**it grieves me**” (*mē* here is accusative, “me,” the one afflicted by the regret) — “*I regret [it].*” It comes from the verb **paenitēre**, “to cause regret,” the direct ancestor of English **penitent**, **penitence**, and **repent**.

Where **ignōsce mihi** asks someone to **forgive** you, **paenitet mē** simply names your own **regret** — closer to “I’m sorry [that happened]” than to “please forgive me.” The same regret/forgiveness split you’ll meet again and again across languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ignōsce” — forgive — then “mihi,” to me
- the whole phrase — “ignōsce mihi” = forgive me
- the other one — “paenitet mē” = I regret it

Before you move on

What does **ignōsce mihi** literally mean, piece by piece? (“**Forgive to me**” — *ignōscere* “to not-know/overlook” + *mihi* “to me.”) What English words share the *(g)nōscere* root? (**Know, recognize, cognition, notice.**) What’s Latin’s other way to express regret, and how is it different? (**Paenitet mē**, “it grieves me” — names the regret, rather than asking to be forgiven.)

Chapter 5

Days of the Week

5.1 diēs Lūnae to diēs Veneris — the week, before it wore down

Spanish says *lunes*; French says *lundi*. Both are worn-down descendants of something Latin still says in **full**: **diēs Lūnae**, “the **day of the Moon**.” This lesson gives you the un-eroded originals.

You’ll want to know: The five weekdays, spelled out in full

Each weekday is simply **diēs** (“day”) plus a **planet-god’s name in the genitive** (“of _____”):

Latin	literally	planet-god	worn down to (Spanish / French)
diēs Lūnae	day of the Moon	Luna	lunes / lundi
diēs Mārtis	day of Mars	Mars	martes / mardi
diēs Mercuriī	day of Mercury	Mercury	miércoles / mercredi
diēs Iovis	day of Jupiter	Jupiter (<i>Iuppiter</i>)	jueves / jeudi
diēs Veneris	day of Venus	Venus	viernes / vendredi

Later languages kept only fragments of this phrase — a bare **-s**, a bare **-di** — but you’re now looking at the whole thing, still standing.

Why it's said this way

Rome didn't always keep a seven-day planetary week. For much of the Republic, Romans ran an **eight-day market cycle** (letters *A* through *H*, not planets at all). The **planetary week** — the Sun, Moon, and five visible planets, each ruling a day, in a fixed order — spread into Rome later, from Hellenistic astrology, and only gradually displaced the older market cycle. So *diēs Lūnae* and its siblings are themselves a Roman **adoption**, not an ancient Roman invention — a system Rome picked up and then passed on, worn down, to Spanish and French centuries later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*diēs Lūnae*” — day of the Moon — then “*diēs Mārtis*,” day of Mars
- all five in a row — “*diēs Lūnae*, *Mārtis*, *Mercuriī*, *Iovis*, *Veneris*”
- the wear-down — “*diēs Mārtis*” became Spanish “*martes*,” French “*mardi*”

Before you move on

What does ***diēs Mārtis*** literally mean, and what does it become in Spanish and French? (“**Day of Mars**” — *martes* / *mardi*.) Did Rome always use a seven-day planetary week? (**No** — for much of the Republic it ran an eight-day market cycle; the planetary week arrived later, from Hellenistic astrology.) What holds every Latin weekday name together? (***diēs*** “day” + the planet-god’s name in the **genitive**, “of ____.”)

5.2 *diēs Saturnī*, *diēs Sōlis* — Saturday and Sunday, before the renaming

The Roman planetary week had **seven** days, not five. The last two — Saturn’s and the Sun’s — tell a story neither Spanish nor French kept: a **religious renaming** that some languages accepted, and others didn’t.

You'll want to know: The two original names

- **diēs Saturnī** — “**day of Saturn.**” This one survives almost untouched in English: **Saturday** (Old English *Sæternesdæg*) is a **direct borrowing** of the Latin god’s own name — the one weekday English kept a **Roman** god outright, rather than swapping in a Germanic equivalent, because there was no obvious Germanic god to stand in for stern old Saturn.
- **diēs Sōlis** — “**day of the Sun.**” Also a direct hit in English: **Sunday** (*Sunnandæg*), a plain translation — the Sun didn’t need a separate Germanic identity to be swapped in.

Why it’s said this way

As Christianity spread through the Empire, Latin usage **replaced** both pagan names:

- **diēs Saturnī** → **Sabbatum**, borrowing the Jewish **Sabbath** (Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest”).
- **diēs Sōlis** → **diēs Dominica**, “the **Lord’s** day” (*Dominus*, “lord”).

Spanish (*sábado*, *domingo*) and **French** (*samedi*, *dimanche*) inherited these newer, **Christianized** names. **English never made the swap** — so, unexpectedly, **English’s Saturday and Sunday are the older, more pagan forms**, while Spanish and French’s weekend names are the **newer**, religiously rewritten ones. The direction of “old vs. new” flips depending which language you’re standing in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “diēs Saturnī” — day of Saturn — then “diēs Sōlis,” day of the Sun
- English kept these directly — “Saturday, Sunday”
- Spanish/French renamed them — “sábado/samedi (Sabbath), domingo/ dimanche (the Lord’s day)”

Before you move on

What did Rome originally call Saturday and Sunday? (**Diēs Saturnī** “day of Saturn,” **diēs Sōlis** “day of the Sun.”) Which modern language kept these pagan names **directly**, and which two languages **renamed** them? (**English** kept them (*Saturday, Sunday*); **Spanish and French** replaced them with the Christian *Sabbatum* / *diēs Dominica*.) So which is actually “older” — English’s weekend names, or Spanish’s? (**English’s** — Spanish’s are the later, Christianized rewrite.)

Chapter 6

Colours

6.1 niger, albus — Latin’s black and white, each with a shine-twin

You’ve seen **niger** already, hiding inside French *noir* and Spanish *negro*. Here’s what those daughter languages left behind: Latin didn’t have just one word for black, or just one for white — it had **two of each**, split by **brightness**, not just hue.

You’ll want to know: Two blacks, two whites

- **niger** = “black” with a **gleam** — a shiny, lustrous black. This is the one that survives into Romance (*noir, negro, nero*).
- **āter** = “black” that’s **dull, matte, lightless** — the flatter, duller black. (English keeps a fossil of it in **atrocious** and **atrociousness** — something so dark/dreadful it’s “black” in the *āter* sense.)
- **albus** = “white” that’s **plain, dull, matte** — this is the one that mostly faded from Romance’s everyday vocabulary (surviving in Spanish *alba*/French *aube*, “dawn,” rather than as the everyday color word).
- **candidus** = “white” with a **shine, a gleam, a glow** — bright white. English keeps this one working hard: **candid** (originally “shining bright,” then “morally bright/honest”), **candidate** (Romans running for office wore a bleached, gleaming-white toga, the *toga candida*), and **candle**.

Why it's said this way

Romance languages mostly **dropped** this shine-vs-matte split and kept only one word per color (*niger* survived for black; *albus* and *candidus* both survive, but neither became the plain everyday “white” in most daughter languages — Spanish and French instead borrowed a **Germanic** word, *blanco/ blanc*, for their everyday white, as you may already have seen). So Latin’s four color-words shrank to cover just two basic ideas — brightness stopped being how Latin-descended languages sort black and white.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “niger” — gleaming black — then “āter,” dull black
- “albus” — dull white — then “candidus,” shining white
- the English fossils — “atrocious” (āter), “candid, candidate” (candidus)

Before you move on

What distinguished Latin’s two black words, and its two white words? (**Brightness** — *niger* “gleaming black” vs. *āter* “dull black”; *candidus* “shining white” vs. *albus* “dull white.”) Which two English words come from *candidus*, and why does *candidate* mean what it does? (**Candid** and **candidate** — Roman office-seekers wore a bleached-white *toga candida*.) Did Romance keep this four-way split? (**No** — it settled on one plain word per color, and Spanish/French even borrowed a **Germanic** word for everyday white.)

6.2 **ruber, caeruleus — a rock-solid red, and a shaky blue**

One of these two words is about as old and stable a color-word as language gets. The other is a genuine puzzle — because Latin, like a surprising number of ancient languages, never quite settled on a clean word for “blue.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

ruber (“red”) descends from PIE *h₁rewd^h*-, a root so old it also gives English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and German **rot**. Latin’s own family used **two** everyday variants of this root — **rubeus** and **russus** — and Romance split them between languages: French **rouge** comes from *rubeus*; Spanish **rojo** comes from *russus*. Different Latin words, same ancient root, same color.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

You might expect a clean Latin ancestor for “blue” the way *ruber* is for red. There isn’t really one. **Caeruleus** is the closest word Latin had — and it’s a much fuzzier idea than *ruber*: it covers the color of the **sky** and the **sea** (*caeruleum mare*, “the blue/dark sea”), but it can also shade toward **dark green** or simply “**dark**,” depending on context. It isn’t a fixed, single hue-word the way *ruber* clearly is.

This isn’t just a Latin quirk. Classicists and linguists have long noted that **many ancient languages lacked a clean, stable basic word for blue** — Ancient Greek is the most famous case (Homer’s “**wine-dark sea**,” never a simple “blue sea”). Across many language families, “blue” tends to be one of the **last** basic color words to settle into place, historically — sometimes splitting off late from words that also covered green, dark, or grey. Latin’s *caeruleus* looks like part of that same broader pattern, though the exact reasons are still debated among linguists rather than fully settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ruber” — red — the ancient, PIE-rooted color word
- its two children — “rubeus → French rouge,” “russus → Spanish rojo”
- “caeruleus” — sea/sky-colored — Latin’s shakiest, least fixed color word

Before you move on

What PIE root gives **ruber**, and what English words share it? (*h₁rewd^h*- — **red, rust, ruddy**.) Which two Latin red-words split between French and Spanish, and which went where? (**Rubeus** → **French rouge**; **russus** → **Spanish rojo**.) Why is **caeruleus** a shakier word than *ruber*? (**It covers sea/sky and can shade toward dark or green** — it was never a single fixed “blue,” a pattern linguists have noticed across many ancient languages, most famously Greek’s “wine-dark sea.”)

Chapter 7

Family

7.1 pater, mater — the oldest words, kept close to the source

“Father” and “mother” are among the **oldest reconstructible words in human language**. Latin kept them almost exactly as they were; English took the very same ancestor down a different road.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

- **pater** (“father”) ← PIE *ph₂tēr*.
- **māter** (“mother”) ← PIE *méh₂tēr*.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Here’s the point worth getting exactly right: **pater and English father are not one derived from the other**. Both descend **independently, in parallel**, from the same PIE word. Latin simply kept the ancestral **p** and **t** close to unchanged; the Germanic branch that produced English took a separate route through **Grimm’s Law**, which shifted that same inherited **p** → **f** and **t** → **th**:

PIE ancestor	Latin	Germanic → English
<i>ph₂tēr</i>	pater	father
<i>méh₂tēr</i>	māter	mother

So *pater* and *father* are **siblings**, sharing one parent-word thousands of years back — not a case of English borrowing or descending from

Latin. *Pater* also gives Latin (and later English, through Latin) the whole “of-a-parent” family: **paternus** (“fatherly,” → English *paternal*) and **māternus** (→ *maternal*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pater, māter” — father, mother
- the relationship — “cousins, not ancestor and descendant”
- “pater → paternus → paternal; māter → māternus → maternal”

Before you move on

Does English *father* come **from** Latin *pater*? (**No** — both descend **independently** from the same PIE word, *ph₂tēr*.) What sound-law explains the difference between them? (**Grimm’s Law** — the Germanic branch shifted the inherited *p* → *f*, *t* → *th*; Latin kept them.) What Latin adjectives give English *paternal* and *maternal*? (**Paternus, māternus**.)

7.2 frater, soror — Latin’s original siblings, before Spanish moved on

Two more ancient words — and a preview of a twist: these are the very words that later got **pushed aside** in everyday Latin, on the road to Spanish.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

- **frāter** (“brother”) ← PIE *b^hréh₂tēr*.
- **soror** (“sister”) ← PIE *swésōr*.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Same rule as *pater/māter*: **frāter** is **not** the source of English “**brother**” — they’re **cousins**, both from *b^hréh₂tēr*, with Grimm’s Law shifting the Germanic branch’s **b^h** → **b** while Latin developed its own

f (from an earlier $b^h \rightarrow f$ shift already inside Latin itself).

Soror is the more surprising one. English **sister** looks nothing like *soror* — and that’s because Latin **dropped** the *w* from the PIE cluster *sw-* (giving plain *s-*), while the Germanic branch **kept** the *w* far longer (Old English had *sweostor*). So *soror* and *sister* are, once again, **cousins from the same PIE word**, *swésōr* — neither one turned into the other; each branch just handled that opening *sw-* differently.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the twist: classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, “a brother of the same blood,” to mark a *full* sibling. Over time, in everyday (Vulgar) Latin, that **adjective** *germānus* took over the whole job, and **frāter itself faded out of common use** — which is exactly why Spanish says **hermano**, not a descendant of *frāter* at all. (French *frère* took the opposite path and kept *frāter* as its everyday word — different Latin regions, different survivors.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “frāter, soror” — brother, sister
- the cousin relationship — “frāter/brother and soror/sister are BOTH parallel descendants, not one from the other”
- the twist — “frāter germānus” → just “germānus” → Spanish “hermano”

Before you move on

Is English “sister” descended from Latin *soror*? (**No** — both are cousins from PIE *swésōr*; Latin dropped the *w*, Germanic kept it longer.) What Latin phrase eventually replaced *frāter* in everyday speech, and where does it show up today? (**Frāter germānus** → just *germānus* → Spanish **hermano**.) Did every Romance language make that same swap? (**No** — French kept *frāter* as *frère*; Spanish moved on to *germānus*.)

Chapter 8

Head and Hand

8.1 caput — the head, still working two thousand years later

Few Latin words stayed as busy in English as this one. And yet — one of Latin’s own descendants **abandoned** it for the actual body part.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

caput, capitis — “**head**.” A perfectly ordinary noun, and one of Latin’s most productive exports:

English	literally
captain	the “head” of a ship or unit
capital	the “head” city, or the “head” sum of money
de capitate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange terms under “little-head” headings — hence, to yield

Spanish kept *caput* as its everyday word too: **cabeza** descends from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*).

Why it’s said this way

French had *caput* available — and **dropped it** for the body part entirely. Instead French says **tête**, from Latin **testa**, “an earthenware pot, a shell.” Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English speakers

say “noggin” (a small mug), and in Gaul, that joke eventually **replaced** *caput* as the everyday word. *Caput* didn’t disappear from French, though — it survives there too, just not for the actual head: **chef** (“chief”), **chapitre**, **capital**, **capitaine**.

So three languages took three different paths with the very same word: **Spanish** kept *caput* as the plain, everyday “head”; **French** demoted it to “chief/chapter/capital” and reached for a pot-joke instead; **English** never used it for the body part at all, only for these borrowed “head of something” senses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “caput, capitis” — head
- the English family — “captain, capital, decapitate, capitulate”
- the twist — French swapped *caput* out for *testa*, “pot”

Before you move on

What does **caput** mean, and what English words come from it? (“**Head**” — *captain*, *capital*, *decapitate*, *capitulate*.) Did every Romance language keep it as the everyday word for “head”? (**No** — Spanish did (*cabeza*); French replaced it with **testa**, “pot,” soldiers’ slang for the skull.) Where does *caput* survive in French, if not as “head”? (**Chef**, **chapitre**, **capital**, **capitaine**.)

8.2 manus — the hand, and a famous grammatical exception

Here’s a word that’s productive in English *and* grammatically odd in Latin itself — an oddity that then rode straight through into Spanish.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

manus, **manūs** — “**hand**.” It belongs to Latin’s **4th declension** — a group of nouns ending in *-us* that runs **overwhelmingly mascu-**

line: *frūctus* (“fruit”), *exercitus* (“army”), *senātus* (“senate”), *portus* (“port”) are all masculine. **Manus is one of only a handful of exceptions** in that declension — feminine, alongside *anus* (“old woman”) and *domus* (“house,” though *domus* is even messier: it mixes 4th- and 2nd-declension endings throughout its own paradigm) — for reasons tied to each noun’s own ancient history, not a rule you could predict from the *-us* ending alone.

That oddity didn’t stay buried in Latin grammar books: Spanish’s word for hand, **mano**, inherited *manus*’s feminine gender directly — which is exactly why *mano* is famously feminine despite ending in **-o**, the ending that signals *masculine* in nearly every other Spanish noun. One small Latin exception, carried whole into a completely different pattern in a daughter language, centuries later.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>facere</i> , “to make”)
manuscript	written by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>scribere</i>)
maintain	hold in the hand (<i>manū tenēre</i>)
manage	to handle

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*manus*, *manūs*” — hand
- the exception — “feminine, unlike *frūctus*, *exercitus*, *senātus*”
- the English family — “manual, manufacture, maintain, manage”

Before you move on

What gender is **manus**, and is that typical for its declension? (**Feminine** — unusual, since the 4th declension runs mostly **masculine**; *manus* is one of a few exceptions, alongside *domus* and *anus*.)

What Spanish word inherited this exact oddity? (**Mano** — feminine despite ending in *-o*.) Give an English word from *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage.**)

Chapter 9

Seasons

9.1 *vēr*, *aestās*, *autumnus*, *hiems* — Latin’s own four seasons

Four Latin nouns, one for each season — and a genuine surprise about which ones actually survived into Spanish and French as ordinary words.

You’ll want to know: The four seasons, plain and simple

Latin	meaning
<i>vēr</i> , <i>vēris</i>	spring
<i>aestās</i> , <i>aestātis</i>	summer (also just “heat”)
<i>autumnus</i> , <i>autumnī</i>	autumn
<i>hiems</i> , <i>hiemis</i>	winter

Why it’s said this way

autumnus survived plainly: it’s the direct ancestor of Spanish *otoño*, French *automne*, and English *autumn* itself — no detours.

But **vēr** and **hiems**, the plain nouns for spring and winter, mostly **didn’t** make it into everyday Romance vocabulary. Instead, Spanish and French built brand-new words out of **adjective phrases** describing those seasons:

- Not *vēr* alone, but a Vulgar Latin phrase/reanalysis, **prīma vēra** (roughly “**first spring**”) → Spanish *primavera*, French (originally) *primevère* — later displaced there by *printemps*

(“first-time,” from *primum tempus*, the very same “adjective + tempus” recipe as winter’s word below; *primevère* narrowed to just mean “**primrose**” today) — and Italian *primavera*, still the everyday word there.

- Not *hiems* alone, but **hibernum (tempus)**, “the wintry [time]” → Spanish *invierno*, French *hiver* — the same root as English **hibernate**.

Aestās (“summer/heat”) did survive directly into French *été* — but Spanish took yet another path: it built **vērānum (tempus)** (“of spring”) from *vēr* itself, and that word’s *meaning* later drifted forward to name **summer** instead of spring, giving Spanish *verano* — leaving *primavera* to do spring’s job.

So the picture is mixed, not a clean split: **autumnus** cruised straight through into Spanish, French, and English unchanged; **aestās** cruised through into French (*été*) but got replaced in Spanish; **vēr** and **hiems**, the plain nouns for spring and winter, essentially left **no** everyday trace in either language — both were replaced by phrase-built words instead (or, in *verano*’s case, by a related word whose meaning simply moved).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*vēr*, *aestās*, *autumnus*, *hiems*” — the four seasons
- the one that survived plainly — “*autumnus* → *otoño*, *automne*, *autumn*”
- the two built from phrases — “*prīma vēra* → *primavera*,” “*hībernum* → *invierno*, *hiver*”

Before you move on

What are Latin’s four season-nouns? (**Vēr**, **aestās**, **autumnus**, **hiems**.) Which one survived plainly into Spanish, French, and English? (**Autumnus** → *otoño*, *automne*, *autumn*.) What did Spanish and French build instead of the plain words *vēr* and *hiems*? (**Adjective phrases** — *prīma vēra* “first spring” → *primavera*/*primevère*; *hībernum* “wintry” → *invierno*/*hiver*.)

Chapter 10

Water, Wine, and Bread

10.1 aqua, vīnum — one word worn thin, one word untouched

Two everyday Latin nouns — and two wildly different fates. One of Rome’s daughters wore this word down to almost nothing. The other word barely moved at all, anywhere.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

aqua, aquae — “**water**.” Spanish and Italian kept it close to whole: **agua, acqua**. French, though, eroded it further than almost any other Latin word in this course: *aqua* → *eue* → *eaue* → **eau** — three written letters, *e-a-u*, spelling one bare vowel sound, “oh.” Compare *caput*, which French similarly abandoned as an everyday word (for *testa*) — *aqua* wasn’t replaced, but it was worn down almost to nothing while staying in place.

English kept the **whole, undamaged** word as a learned borrowing: **aquatic, aquarium, aqueduct, aqualung** all sound exactly like their Latin ancestor.

You’ll want to know: vīnum — survived, everywhere, almost untouched

vīnum, vīnī — “**wine**.” Unlike *aqua* and *caput*, this word simply **didn’t erode much in any direction**: Spanish *vino*, French *vin*, Italian *vino* — all close to the original. Germanic borrowed it directly and early, giving English **wine** itself. Centuries later, English picked up more of the family — this time secondhand, through **French**: **vine** (< OF *vigne* < *vīnea*, “vineyard”),

vinegar (< OF *vinaigre*, *vin* + *aigre*, ultimately *acer* “sour”), **vintage** (< OF *vendage* < *vīndēmia*, *vīnum* + *dēmere* “to harvest”). **Vineyard** isn’t a borrowing at all — English built it at home, compounding the already-borrowed “wine” with native “yard.” Few Latin words traveled this far, by this many different roads, and stayed this recognizable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aqua” — water — then the daughters: “agua, acqua, eau”
- “vīnum” — wine — then: “vino, vin, vino, wine”
- the contrast — aqua wore thin in French; vīnum stayed solid everywhere

Before you move on

Which Latin word for a drink got worn down almost to nothing, and in which language? (**Aqua**, in **French** — down to a bare “eau.”) Which word barely changed **anywhere**, surviving into every Romance daughter and into English too? (**Vīnum** — wine, vino, vin, vino.) Where did the *whole*, undamaged form of *aqua* survive in English? (**Aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct** — learned borrowings, not everyday words.)

10.2 pānis — bread, and the friend who shares it

One Latin word for bread, surviving whole across every Romance daughter — and hiding, inside a compound, one of the loveliest word-stories in English.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

pānis, **pānis** — “**bread**.” Spanish **pan**, French **pain**, Italian **pane** all continue it directly — bread mattered enough to keep its own name everywhere.

You'll want to know: **com-** + **pānis** — “sharing bread”

Add the prefix **com-** (“with, together”) and you get **compānio/ compānia** — a Vulgar Latin coinage, not a Classical-era word — literally “**one you share bread with,**” the direct ancestor of English **companion** and **company**. A *company* was, at first, nothing more than a group who ate together.

Why it's said this way

English only kept the **friendship** half of this word — *companion* has nothing to do with actual bread anymore to an English speaker. **Spanish**, though, still keeps **both halves** traceably related: **pan** (the bread itself) and **compañero** (the friend, “one who shares *pan*”) sit right next to each other in the same language, both transparently built from the same root. Latin's *pānis* split into two separate lives in English, but stayed one visible family in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pānis” — bread — then “pan, pain, pane”
- “com- + pānis” — “with bread” — companion, company
- the contrast — English kept only the friend; Spanish kept both the bread and the friend

Before you move on

What does **pānis** give Spanish, French, and Italian directly? (**Pan, pain, pane** — bread.) What English words come from *com- + pānis*, and what do they literally mean? (**Companion, company** — “one you **share bread with.**”) Does English still connect “companion” to actual bread? (**No** — only Spanish keeps both *pan* and *compañero* traceably related.)

Chapter 11

Months

11.1 Iānuārius to December — the twelve months, before and after the rename

You'll meet these twelve names again, worn down, in Spanish and French. Latin lets you see something they can't show you directly: **two of these months used to have completely different names.**

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Latin	who / what
Iānuārius	Janus , the two-faced god of doors and beginnings
Februārius	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
Mārtius	Mars , the war-god
Aprīlis	perhaps aperīre , “to open” (buds opening)
Māius	Maia , goddess of growth
Iūnius	Juno , queen of the gods
Quīntīlis	literally “ the fifth ” (<i>quīntus</i>) — later renamed Iūlius
Sextīlis	literally “ the sixth ” (<i>sextus</i>) — later renamed Augustus
September	“ the seventh ” (<i>septem</i>)
Octōber	“ the eighth ” (<i>octō</i>)
November	“ the ninth ” (<i>novem</i>)
December	“ the tenth ” (<i>decem</i>)

Why it’s said this way

You’ll often hear that **Julius Caesar and Augustus “added” two months** to the calendar, which is why September through December no longer match their numbers. That’s **not what happened**. Rome’s year, centuries earlier, had already been expanded from ten months to twelve by adding **Iānuārius** and **Februārius** at the front — that’s the real reason *September* (“seventh”) ended up as the **ninth** month. *Quīntīlis* (“the fifth”) and *Sextīlis* (“the sixth”) already existed as ordinary, plainly-numbered months, right alongside *September* through *December*. Long after Julius Caesar’s death, the Senate simply **renamed** *Quīntīlis* to **Iūlius** in his honor; decades later, Augustus received the same honor, and *Sextīlis* became **Augustus**. No months were created — two old, numbered ones just got new names, and Latin’s fifth and sixth months quietly disappeared from view, hiding inside *julio/juillet* and *agosto/août* in every daughter language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Iānuārius, Februārius, Mārtius, Aprīlis, Māius, Iūnius, Quīntilis, Sextilis, September, Octōber, November, December”
- the originals — “Quīntilis, the fifth” / “Sextilis, the sixth”
- the correction — “renamed, not inserted”

Before you move on

What were *Iūlius* and *Augustus* called **before** they were renamed, and what did those names mean? (**Quīntilis** “the fifth” and **Sextilis** “the sixth.”) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus add new months to the calendar? (**No** — they got two already-existing months **renamed** after them.) What actually caused *September–December* to fall out of step with their numbers? (**Adding Iānuārius and Februārius** to the front of the year, centuries earlier.)

Chapter 12

Noon and Midnight

12.1 medius diēs, media nox — the source phrase, worn down at different rates

Here's the same Latin phrase, followed into three languages — and each one treated it completely differently.

You'll want to know: The two phrases

- **medius diēs** — literally “**the middle day**,” meaning “**midday, noon**” (*medius*, “middle” + *diēs*, “day”).
- **media nox** — literally “**the middle night**,” meaning “**midnight**” (*media*, the feminine of *medius* + *nox*, *noctis*, “night”).

Why it's said this way

- **Spanish** kept **both halves of both phrases** as fully ordinary, living words: *medio/media* (“middle”) and *día/noche* (“day/night”) — giving *mediodía* and *medianoche*, entirely transparent.
- **French** eroded the **same phrase unevenly**. *Nox* survived as the everyday word *nuit* (“night”) — still fully transparent inside *minuit*. But *diēs* did **not** survive as French's everyday word for “day” (that's *jour* instead) — so inside *midi*, the *-di* fragment is a fossil, recognizable only from weekday names like *lundi*, *mardi*, not from any living, standalone word for “day.”
- **English** didn't inherit this phrase for “noon” **at all**. Instead, English's *noon* comes from an entirely different Latin phrase:

nōna hōra, “the **ninth hour**” — originally meaning roughly 3 p.m. (counting from a sunrise start), it drifted steadily earlier over the centuries until it settled on **midday**.

One Latin phrase, three completely different fates: fully kept, half-worn, and simply replaced by another Latin phrase altogether.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**medius diēs**” — mid-day, then “**media nox**” — mid-night
- the three fates — “Spanish kept both halves, French kept only night, English used a different phrase entirely”
- “**nōna hōra**” — the ninth hour — English’s real ancestor for “noon”

Before you move on

What do **medius diēs** and **media nox** literally mean? (“The middle day” = noon; “the middle night” = midnight.) Which language kept both halves of both phrases fully transparent? (**Spanish** — *mediodía*, *medianoche*.) Which language kept “night” but not “day”? (**French** — *nuit* stayed alive, *-di* became a fossil.) Does English’s *noon* come from this same phrase? (**No** — from *nōna hōra*, “the ninth hour,” which drifted from afternoon to midday.)

Chapter 13

Telling Time

13.1 hōra — the source word, and an hour that wasn’t always 60 minutes

You already met **nōna hōra**, “the ninth hour,” in an earlier lesson — now meet the word itself, and an honest surprise about what a Roman “hour” actually was.

You’ll want to know: hōra ← Greek hōrā

hōra = “**hour**” — borrowed from **Greek hōrā**, “a season, the right time, a time of day” (the Greek goddesses of the seasons, the *Hōrai*, share this root). Latin narrowed the broader Greek sense down to today’s specific meaning: one twelfth of the day.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the part that trips people up: the Romans divided **daylight** — sunrise to sunset — into **12 equal hōrae**, and **night** into another 12. But since daylight itself is longer in summer and shorter in winter, **each hōra stretched or shrank with the seasons**: a summer daytime hōra in Rome could run close to 75 modern minutes, a winter one closer to 45. Only at the two equinoxes did an hōra land close to today’s fixed 60 minutes. This is exactly why **nōna hōra** (“the ninth hour,” counted from sunrise) landed around 3 p.m. at the equinox but could shift earlier or later depending on the season — and why it drifted, over centuries, into the fixed clock-time we call “noon.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

language	word	what happened
Spanish	<i>hora</i>	inherited almost unchanged
French	<i>heure</i>	inherited, worn down further
German	<i>Uhr</i>	not inherited — borrowed centuries later, separately
English	<i>hour</i>	inherited via French

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hōra” — the source word, Greek *hōrā* underneath
- the honest surprise — a Roman *hōra* stretched and shrank with the seasons, it wasn’t a fixed 60 minutes
- “hōra / hora / heure / hour” — one root, four different fates

Before you move on

What Greek word is *hōra* from, and what did it originally mean? (*hōrā* — “a season, the right time.”) Was a Roman *hōra* always 60 minutes long? (**No** — it was 1/12 of that day’s actual daylight or nighttime span, so it stretched in summer and shrank in winter.) Which of Spanish, French, and German did **not** directly inherit this word from Latin? (**German** — it borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.)

Chapter 14

Asking Someone's Age

14.1 *vīgintī annōs nātus sum* — a THIRD way to say your age

You already know that Spanish and French say “I HAVE my years,” and German/English say “I AM my years.” Here’s the honest surprise: Latin itself did **neither**.

You’ll want to know: *vīgintī annōs nātus sum* — “twenty years born”

vīgintī annōs nātus sum = “I am twenty years old” — literally “I am, having been born, twenty years” (a man speaking; a woman says *nāta*). Taken apart:

- *nātus/nāta* — “born,” the perfect passive participle of *nāscor*, “to be born” (the same root behind English **nature**, **native**, **nation**, **innate**).
- *annōs* — “years,” in the **accusative case**, marking **duration** — “for twenty years [of life so far].” This is the same accusative-of-duration you’d use for “I studied **for three years**” (*trēs annōs*).
- *sum* — “I am.”

So the whole phrase reads: “I am — having been born [and living] twenty years [so far].” Cicero uses exactly this pattern in *Cato Maior de Senectute* (§14), in Cato’s own voice: **quīnque et sexāgintā annōs nātus**, “having

been born sixty-five years,” i.e., “at sixty-five years old” — the same section also gives Ennius’s age as **annōs septuāgintā nātus**, “seventy.”

Why it’s said this way

You’ve already met the clean Romance/Germanic split for this concept — Romance languages **have** their years (*tengo, j’ai, ho*), Germanic languages **are** their years (*ich bin, I am*). Here’s the twist: **Latin itself used neither construction.** Classical Latin’s *nātus* + accusative-of-duration pattern is a **third**, distinct grammatical shape — not “having” years, not simply “being” a number, but “being **born-for-that-long**.” The Romance “have your years” pattern (*habēre* + years) that Spanish, French, and Italian all inherited is a **Vulgar Latin innovation** that arose **after** Classical Latin, replacing the older *nātus* construction — so Spanish’s *tengo veinte años* is NOT a direct continuation of how Cicero would have said it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*vīgintī annōs nātus sum*” — I am twenty years old, literally “born twenty years”
- “*nātus*” — born, same root as English “native, nature, nation”
- the honest surprise — this is a **THIRD** pattern, neither “have” nor simple “be”

Before you move on

What does ***vīgintī annōs nātus sum*** literally mean? (“I am, having been **born**, twenty years” — using the perfect participle *nātus* + the accusative of duration.) Does this match Romance’s “have your years” pattern? (**No** — that’s a **later Vulgar Latin innovation**, not what Classical Latin did.) What English words share the root of *nātus*? (**Native, nature, nation, innate.**)

Chapter 15

Weather

15.1 *tempestās* — one Latin word widened, its own derivative narrowed

You’ve seen Spanish’s *tiempo* mean both “time” and “weather” at once. Here’s the honest history: Classical Latin actually kept these apart — but it wasn’t Spanish that changed that. It happened inside Latin itself.

You’ll want to know: *tempestās* — a derivative of *tempus*, specialized for weather, then narrowed further

tempestās = “weather, storm” — grammatically a **derivative noun** built on **tempus** (“time”), and by Classical Latin it had already **specialized**: *tempus* stayed strictly “time,” while *tempestās* carried the weather/storm sense on its own. (English kept this split too: *tempestās* gives **tempest**, “a violent storm,” while *tempus* gives **temporal**, **tempo**.)

Be careful with what happened next, though: Spanish’s single *tiempo* is **not** these two words merging back together. Later — still **within Latin’s own history**, before Spanish, French, or Italian existed as separate languages — **tempus itself re-widened** to also cover “weather” (that’s why French *temps* and Italian *tempo* carry the exact same double sense; this happened at the shared Latin stage, not as a Spanish-only development). Meanwhile *tempestās* kept going too, narrowing further to mean specifically “**storm**” — and it’s still alive in Spanish today as its own separate word, **tempestad** (“storm, tempest”), sitting right alongside *tiempo*. So it’s one word (*tempus*) widening back out, not two words fusing into one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tempestās” — weather/storm, a derivative of *tempus*, “time,” narrowed today to Spanish’s “tempestad”
- “tempus” — time, later widened inside Latin to weather too

Before you move on

Were *tempus* and *tempestās* the same word in Classical Latin? (**No** — *tempestās* is a derivative that specialized for weather/storm, while *tempus* stayed strictly “time.”) Did Spanish merge these two words back together? (**No** — *tempus* itself re-widened to cover “weather” already within Latin’s own history, shared by French/Italian too; *tempestās* kept narrowing and survives separately as Spanish *tempestad*.)

15.2 pluit, calor, sol — three pieces of weather language

You know the history of **tempestās**. Now learn how Latin actually states rain, heat, and sun.

Grammar Lens: pluit — a subjectless weather verb

Latin uses dedicated impersonal verbs with no subject at all:

- **pluit** — it rains
- **ningit** — it snows
- **tonat** — it thunders

Pluit is the ancestor of Spanish **llueve**. Its opening follows the same **pl-** → **ll-** path as *plover* → *llover*, *clāmāre* → *llamar*, and *flamma* → *llama*.

This verb pattern resembles English “it rains” more closely than Spanish **hace calor**. Spanish kept the dedicated verb for rain but built a new **hacer** expression for heat, cold, and sun.

You'll want to know: calor and sol — carried straight through

Latin **calor** (“heat”) and **sol** (“sun”) are also Spanish **calor** and **sol**. These words needed no visible sound change at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pluit” — it rains; ancestor of Spanish *llueve*
- “calor” — heat, unchanged in Spanish
- “sol” — sun, unchanged in Spanish

Before you move on

How does Latin say “it rains”? (**Pluit**, with no subject.) What sound path connects it to Spanish **llueve**? (**pl-** → **ll-**.) Which two weather nouns pass into Spanish unchanged? (**Calor** and **sol**.) Does Latin use a counterpart of Spanish **hacer** for all three ideas? (**No** — it uses dedicated impersonal weather verbs.)

Chapter 16

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

16.1 *ūndecim*, *vīgintī* — the source numbers, including a genuine oddity

You’ve seen Spanish’s *once* through *quince* as fused, worn-down compounds. Here are the whole, un-fused Latin originals — plus a real quirk in Latin’s own counting system that Spanish quietly dropped.

You’ll want to know: *ūndecim*–*quīndecim* — plain “X-ten” compounds

Latin	literally
<i>ūndecim</i>	<i>ūnus</i> + <i>decim</i> , “one-ten”
<i>duodecim</i>	<i>duo</i> + <i>decim</i> , “two-ten”
<i>tredecim</i>	<i>trēs</i> + <i>decim</i> , “three-ten”
<i>quattuordecim</i>	<i>quattuor</i> + <i>decim</i> , “four-ten”
<i>quīndecim</i>	<i>quīnque</i> + <i>decim</i> , “five-ten”

Straightforward additive compounds — number, then *decim* (“ten,” from **decem**). These are the direct, whole ancestors of Spanish’s *once*, *doce*, *trece*, *catorce*, *quince* — fused down over the centuries into single words.

You’ll want to know: *sēdecim*, *septendecim* — still additive

sēdecim (16, “six-ten”) and *septendecim* (17, “seven-ten”) keep the same additive pattern.

Why it's said this way

Here's the real oddity. Latin didn't say "eight-ten" or "nine-ten" for 18 and 19 — it counted **backward from twenty** instead:

duodēvigintī — "two **FROM** twenty" (18) **ūndēvigintī**
— "one **FROM** twenty" (19)

This is genuinely **subtractive** counting, not additive — the same logic behind how Latin also names the day before the Kalends. It's a real irregularity sitting right in the middle of an otherwise perfectly additive system. **Spanish did not inherit this quirk:** *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* are built fresh on the simple "ten-and-X" template, quietly regularizing away something genuinely odd in Latin's own counting.

You'll want to know: vīgintī

vīgintī ("twenty") — the direct, unchanged source of Spanish's *veinte*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ūndecim, duodecim, tredecim, quattuordecim, quīndecim" — the plain "X-ten" compounds
- "duodēvigintī, ūndēvigintī" — 18 and 19, counted BACKWARD from twenty
- "vīgintī" — twenty

Before you move on

- What pattern do *ūndecim* through *quīndecim* follow? (**Additive** — number + *decim*, "ten.")
- What's genuinely odd about Latin's 18 and 19? (They're **subtractive** — *duodēvigintī*/*ūndēvigintī*, literally "two/one FROM twenty," not "eight/nine-ten.")
- Did Spanish keep this pattern? (**No** — *dieciocho*/*diecinueve* use plain addition, regularizing away Latin's quirk.)

Chapter 17

Dog and Cat

17.1 *canis*, *fēlēs*, *cattus* — the expected word, and the word that pushed it out

Spanish’s *perro* mysteriously displaced the word Latin gave it. Here is that word, and a parallel story about “cat.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

canis (“dog”) is the direct source of English **canine**, French **chien**, Italian **cane** — and it’s also the Latin word Spanish **inherited** first, as **can**. But Spanish’s everyday word for dog is *perro* instead, a word with **no confirmed etymology at all** — *can* survives only in archaic or literary use, quietly pushed aside by a newcomer nobody can fully explain.

You’ll want to know: *fēlēs* and *cattus* — a similar displacement, this time INSIDE Latin

Here is a parallel that happened **within Latin itself**, before any Romance language existed:

- **fēlēs** was Classical Latin’s own, original word for “**cat**” — used by Cicero, Pliny, and others, and still preserved today in the scientific name for the domestic cat, *Felis catus*.
- **cattus** (also *catta*) is a **later** word that entered Latin as domestic cats themselves spread along Roman trade routes, out of their point of domestication in **Egypt** (c. 2000 BCE). *Cattus* is most likely

ultimately an **Afro-Asiatic** word (compare Nubian *kadis*, “cat”) — the word traveled **with the animal**.

By around 700 CE, *cattus* had pushed *fēlēs* out of everyday use almost everywhere — it’s *cattus*, not *fēlēs*, that gives Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, and more.

Why it’s said this way

Both “dog” and “cat” show a Latin-inherited word getting pushed aside by a newcomer — but the two stories aren’t equally well understood. *Cattus* replacing *fēlēs* is a well-documented, well-sourced piece of history, with a real trade-route explanation. *Perro* replacing *canis*-derived *can* is genuinely **unexplained** — a real gap in the historical record, not just a simplification for beginners.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “canis” — dog, source of English “canine”
- “fēlēs” — Classical Latin’s own word for cat
- “cattus” — the newcomer that replaced it, probably from Egypt via Africa

Before you move on

- What English word is a direct cousin of **canis**? (**Canine**.)
- Which Latin word for “cat” is older? (**Fēlēs** — Classical Latin’s own word, later displaced by *cattus*.)
- Where does *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, probably from **Egypt**, that traveled with the cat itself.)
- Are the two displacements equally well understood? (**No** — *cattus* has a sourced history; Spanish *perro* remains a genuine mystery.)

Chapter 18

Green and Yellow

18.1 viridis, flāvus — the kept word, and the word Romance abandoned twice over

One of Latin’s color words survived cleanly into Spanish. The other one is a genuine oddity: Latin had a perfectly good word for yellow — and virtually **no** Romance language kept it, though most of them agreed on a surprising replacement together.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

viridis (“**green**”) comes from **virēre**, “**to flourish, to be green, to be vigorous**” — and this is the **direct** source of Spanish’s *verde*, worn down by entirely ordinary sound change (syncope of the medial vowel: *viridis* → *virdis* → *verde*). A clean, uneventful inheritance.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

flāvus (“**yellow, golden, blond**,” often specifically of hair) is a genuine, well-attested Classical Latin color word, from **Proto-Indo-European** **bhleh₃w-* (“shining, light-colored”) — though *lūteus* was Latin’s more neutral, plain “yellow” word in everyday prose. Here’s the honest oddity: almost **no** Romance language kept *flāvus* as its everyday word for “yellow.” Spanish and Portuguese independently reinvented *amarillo/amarelo* from *amarus*, “bitter.” But here’s the genuinely surprising twist: **French’s** *jaune*, **Italian’s** *giallo*, and **Romanian’s** *galben* all converge on a **different shared Latin word** instead — **galbinus**, which meant “**light green**,” not yellow at all. So this isn’t every daughter language scattering off in its own direction — it’s closer to **two** major

replacement stories: Ibero-Romance’s shared “bitter” reinvention, and a much wider swath of Romance sharing *galbinus* instead. *Flāvus* itself didn’t vanish completely — it survives today mainly in **Roman personal names**, like **Flāvius** and **Flāvia**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viridis” — green, direct source of verde
- “flāvus” — yellow, Latin’s own word, almost universally abandoned
- “galbinus” — “light green,” yet somehow the shared source of French’s jaune, Italian’s giallo, AND Romanian’s galben
- “Flāvius” — a Roman name preserving flāvus, where the color word itself didn’t survive

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **viridis**, and what Spanish word does it directly become? (**Virēre**, “to flourish” → **verde**.) Did most Romance languages keep **flāvus** as their word for yellow? (**No.**) What are the **two** main replacement stories, and which languages fall into each? (**Ibero-Romance** — Spanish/Portuguese — independently reinvented *amarillo/amarelo* from “bitter”; **French, Italian, and Romanian** all instead converge on the *same* Latin word, *galbinus*, “light green,” not yellow at all.) Where does *flāvus* mainly survive today? (**Roman personal names**, like *Flāvius* and *Flāvia*.)

Chapter 19

How Are You?

19.1 quid agis?, ut valēs? — “how are you?”, two genuinely Roman ways

Modern languages often teach one fixed “how are you?” formula.
Roman comedy gives you two ordinary questions instead.

Why it’s said this way

Latin has **no single fixed idiom** for “how are you?” the way Spanish has *¿cómo estás?* — but it has **two** genuinely attested colloquial questions, both found repeatedly in **Plautus** and **Terence’s** comedies (the closest thing Latin has to recorded everyday speech):

- **Quid agis?** — literally “**what are you doing?**”, used idiomatically the way English uses “what’s up?” or “how’s it going?”
- **Ut valēs?** — literally “**how do you fare?**”, built on **valēre**, “to be strong, to be well” — the **same verb** as *valē*.

A third phrase, **quōmodo tē habēs?** (“how do you hold yourself?”), shows up constantly in **modern** spoken-Latin teaching materials, and it’s grammatically perfectly sound — but it is **not** actually found in any surviving classical text. Be careful with this one: it’s a reasonable modern construction, not a Roman one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quid agis?” — literally “what are you doing?”
- “ut valēs?” — literally “how do you fare?”
- “quōmodo tē habēs?” — grammatical today, but not classically attested

Before you move on

What does **quid agis?** literally mean? (“**What are you doing?**”) What verb connects **ut valēs?**, **valeō**, and the *valē* you already knew from Chapter 1? (***Valēre***, “to be strong/well.”) Is **quōmodo tē habēs?** genuinely attested in classical Latin? (**No** — grammatically sound, but a modern pedagogical construction, not found in surviving Roman texts.)

19.2 valeō and valē — answer and farewell from one verb

You can ask **ut valēs?**, “how do you fare?” Its most direct answer is already hiding inside the first farewell you learned.

You’ll want to know: valeō — I fare well

The attested reply is **valeō**: “I fare well” or “I am strong.” Plautus’s characters can intensify it as **valeō rēctē** (“I am properly well”) or **valeō et salvōs sum rēctē** (“I am well and safe”).

The dictionary verb is **valēre**, “to be strong, be well.” Watch one stem move through the exchange:

- **ut valēs?** — how do you fare?
- **valeō** — I fare well
- **valē!** — be well!

That last imperative became the Chapter 1 goodbye. Latin’s farewell is therefore a wish for the other person to remain well.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ut valēs?” — how do you fare?
- “valeō” — I fare well
- “valē” — be well; goodbye

Before you move on

What verb unites **ut valēs?**, **valeō**, and **valē**? (**Valēre**, “to be strong or well.”) Which form answers the question? (**Valeō**.) What does the farewell **valē** literally command? (**Be well**.)

19.3 Practice — open, check, answer, close

Nothing new. You already own every word below; this lesson only puts them in order, so that for the first time you can carry a whole Latin exchange from the first breath to the last.

The exchange — five lines, all of them already yours

A: **Salvē! Quid agis?** *Be well! What are you doing?* — “hello, how’s it going?”

B: **Valeō, grātiās tibi agō. Ut valēs?** *I fare well, I give thanks to you. How do you fare?*

A: **Valeō.** — *I fare well.*

B: **Valē!** — *Be well!*, the parting wish

A: **Valē!**

Hear what holds it together. One verb, **valēre** (“to be strong, to be well”), supplies the second question (**valēs**), both answers (**valeō**), and the farewell (**valē**). Latin does not need a separate word for “I”: the **-ō** of *valeō* and *agō* already is it. And the exchange opens and closes on the same wish — *salvē* “be well,” *valē* “be well” — because a Roman greeting is a wish for the other person’s health, coming and going.

Your turn

- *Run through:* both voices, aloud, once straight through
- *Choose:* you meet a whole room, not one person → **salvēte**
- *Say it:* the ending that already means “I” in *valeō* and *agō* — **-ō**

Before you move on

Run the exchange once more without looking. Then: which single verb supplies *valēs*, *valeō*, and *valē*? (**Valēre.**) Which of the two Roman “how are you?” questions is *not* attested? (Neither — both *quid agis?* and *ut valēs?* are real; the modern one was *quōmodo tē habēs?*)

Chapter 20

Exchanging Names

20.1 quid tibi nōmen est?, mihi nōmen est... — “what’s your name?”, the dative way

English says you **have** a name. German says you’re **called** something. Latin does neither — it says the name **belongs to you**, using nothing but a case ending.

You’ll want to know: quid tibi nōmen est? — literally “what is the name TO YOU?”

Quid tibi nōmen est? (“what’s your name?”) is, word for word, “**what** [is] **the-name** [to] **you**?” — no verb for “have,” no verb for “be called.” The name simply **exists**, and **tibi** (“to you,” dative case) says who it belongs to.

You’ll want to know: mihi nōmen est... — the same construction, in reply

The reply follows the identical pattern: **mihi nōmen est** [name] — “[the-name] [is] to-me [name].” This is Latin’s genuine “**dative of possession**”: instead of a possessive verb, the possessor simply sits in the dative case, and the thing possessed — here, **nōmen**, “name” — stays in the nominative, as the sentence’s real subject.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quid tibi nōmen est?” — literally “what’s the name to you?”

- “mihi nōmen est...” — “the name is to me...”
- the case doing the work — dative *tibi/mihi*, not a verb

Before you move on

What case does the possessor sit in, in **mihi nōmen est**? (**Dative** — *mihi*, “to me.”) Does Latin use a verb like “have” or “be called” for this? (**No** — the name simply exists; possession is shown by the dative case alone.) What noun remains the sentence’s grammatical subject? (**Nōmen**, “name.”)

20.2 Mārcus or Mārcō? — a real classical variation

The possessor in Latin’s naming construction is reliably dative. The personal name beside **nōmen**, however, is not locked to one case in every author.

Grammar Lens: The stable frame

The dative possessor appears across authors from Plautus through Livy and Sallust:

puerō nōmen est ... — to the boy the name is ...

That **puerō** does not change. It marks the person who possesses the name.

Grammar Lens: Two habits for the personal name

Cicero tends to keep the personal name nominative, agreeing with **nōmen**, the sentence’s subject:

puerō nōmen est Mārcus

Livy and **Sallust** more often pull the personal name into the dative to match the possessor:

puerō nōmen est Mārcō

The underlying dative-of-possession construction is the same. The

choice between **Mārcus** and **Mārcō** is authorial variation, not evidence that one sentence has stopped using the dative of possession.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “puerō” — to the boy; always the dative possessor
- “Mārcus” — Cicero’s usual nominative pattern
- “Mārcō” — the matching dative found more often in Livy/Sallust

Before you move on

- Which case remains constant for the possessor? (**Dative.**)
- Which author tends toward nominative **Mārcus**? (**Cicero.**)
- Which authors more often use matching dative **Mārcō**? (**Livy and Sallust.**)
- Do the two forms represent different possession constructions? (**No.**)

Chapter 21

Nice to Meet You

21.1 volup est convēnisse — the phrase Latin uses instead of a fixed idiom

Every modern language in this course has one fixed phrase for “nice to meet you.” Latin, honestly, does **not** — but it has something better: a real line from a Roman comedy that does the job.

Why it’s said this way

Plautus’s comedy *Miles Gloriosus* (Act 2, Scene 3) gives us a real line that does exactly this work: “**Tē, [name], volup est convēnisse**” — literally “**you, [name], [it] is-a-pleasure to-have-met,**” or naturally, “**it’s a pleasure to have met you, [name].**” Break it down:

- **volup** — an old, indeclinable word for “**pleasant, pleasing**” (functioning here the way *iuvat*, “it pleases,” would)
- **est** — “[it] **is**”
- **convēnisse** — the **perfect infinitive** of *convenīre*, “to come together, to meet” — “**to have met**”

Put together: “**to have met [you] is a pleasure.**” This is a genuine, attested line — not a modern reconstruction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “volup est convēnisse” — “it’s a pleasure to have met you”
- the pieces — volup (pleasant) + est (is) + convēnisse (to have met)
- the grammar — convēnisse is a perfect infinitive

Before you move on

Does Classical Latin have one single fixed idiom for “nice to meet you”? (**No** — Romans expressed the sentiment according to context.) What real, attested phrase can do the job, and where does it come from? (“**Volup est convēnisse**”, literally “to have met [you] is a pleasure” — **Plautus**, *Miles Gloriosus*.) What kind of infinitive is **convēnisse**? (**Perfect** — “to have met.”)

21.2 Useful phrase, honest context

Volup est convēnisse is genuinely Roman. Now place it in its scene so you know exactly what that evidence does—and does not—prove.

Why it’s said this way

In *Miles Gloriosus*, Sceledrus and Palaestrio are fellow slaves who already know one another. The line welcomes a **chance encounter**. It does not document a fixed formula that Romans always used when introduced to a stranger for the first time.

The phrase still expresses the right sentiment: “to have met you is a pleasure.” Use it as an attested way to do that conversational work, while remembering that Classical Latin has no single fixed counterpart to Spanish *encantado* or German *freut mich*.

Why it’s said this way

Modern spoken-Latin guides may teach **mihi pergrātum est tē convenire**: “it is very pleasing to me to meet you.” Its grammar is sound, but the formula does not occur in surviving classical texts. It is useful modern Latin, not direct evidence of Roman conversational convention.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “volup est convēnisse” — classically attested
- its scene — a chance encounter between people already acquainted
- “mihi pergrātum est tē convenīre” — grammatical, but modern

Before you move on

Is the Plautine line a first-time introduction? (**No — it is a chance encounter between acquaintances.**) Is it still genuinely attested? (**Yes.**) Is **mihi pergrātum est tē convenīre** bad grammar? (**No.**) Is it classically attested? (**No — it is a modern spoken-Latin formula.**)

21.3 Practice — two meetings, each with the right words

English uses one formula for both meetings. Latin does not, and the chapter told you why. So you get two scenes, and the payoff is knowing which words go in which.

The exchange — scene one: strangers, so trade names

A: **Salvē! Quid tibi nōmen est?** *Be well! What is the name to you?*

B: **Mihi nōmen est Mārcus. Quid tibi nōmen est?** *The name to me is Marcus.*

A: **Mihi nōmen est Iūlia.**

B: **Valē!** A: **Valē!**

Mārcus and *Iūlia* are only slots — put your own name there. Notice what is missing: no verb for “have,” no verb for “be called.” The dative *tibi/mihi* carries the possession by itself, and *nōmen* stays the subject.

Scene two is the chance re-encounter — the situation Plautus actually wrote the line for:

A: **Salvē! Quid agis?**

B: **Valeō. Volup est convēnisse!** *I fare well. It is a pleasure to have met [you].*

A: **Valē!**

Your turn

- *Run through:* scene one with your own name in the slot
- *Choose:* a stranger → names; someone you already know → *volup est convēnisse*
- *Choose:* greeting several people at once → **salvēte**

Before you move on

Which case does *mihi* sit in, and what work does it do? (**Dative**; it owns the name without any verb.) Cicero would write *puerō nōmen est Mārcus*; who prefers *Mārcō*? (**Livy and Sallust.**) Is *mihi pergrātum est tē convenīre* good Latin, and is it Roman? (Good grammar; **not attested** — modern.)

Chapter 22

You, Singular and Plural

22.1 $t\bar{u}$, $v\bar{o}s$ — “you,” before politeness got involved

German’s lesson on “you” was about **formality** — *du* versus *Sie*. Latin’s version of this same lesson is about something completely different: plain **number**. Formality hadn’t been invented yet.

You’ll want to know: $t\bar{u}$ — you, one person

$T\bar{u}$ = “**you**,” addressing **one** person. That’s the whole rule — no formal/informal split, just singular number. You’ve already used its dative form, *tibi*, in *quid tibi nōmen est?*

You’ll want to know: $v\bar{o}s$ — you, more than one person

$V\bar{o}s$ = “**you**,” addressing **more than one** person — plain plural, nothing more.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the real teaching point: in **Classical Latin**, this is a **purely grammatical number** distinction. There is **no** formal/informal dimension at all — using *vōs* to politely address a single powerful person had **not yet started**. That habit — plural pronoun used respectfully for one person — only developed later, in **Late Latin**, well after the classical period. It’s the **direct ancestor** of French’s polite *vous*. Careful, though: it is **not** the ancestor of German’s *Sie* from the last lesson — *Sie* solves the same politeness problem in a completely **different**

way, by repurposing an unrelated pronoun (3rd-person plural “they”), not by descending from *vōs* at all. Classical Romans simply didn’t have this option yet: one person was always *tū*, no matter how important they were — though Romans still had **other** ways to show deference, like respectful titles (*domine*, “sir/lord”), just not through the pronoun itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tū*” — you, singular, one person
- “*vōs*” — you, plural, more than one person
- the honest twist — Classical Latin’s *tū/vōs* is PURE number, no politeness at all, unlike German’s *du/Sie*

Before you move on

What’s the difference between ***tū*** and ***vōs*** in Classical Latin — number, or politeness? (**Pure number** — *tū* is singular, *vōs* is plural; no formality dimension existed yet.) When did using *vōs* to politely address one person begin? (**Late Latin**, after the classical period — the direct ancestor of French’s polite *vous*.) Is German’s ***Sie*** descended from *vōs* the same way? (**No** — *Sie* solves the same problem independently, by repurposing 3rd-person plural “they,” not by inheriting from *vōs* at all.)

Chapter 23

You're Welcome

23.1 nihil est — “you’re welcome,” another honest gap

You already learned that Latin has no fixed “nice to meet you.” Here’s the same honest gap again: no fixed reply to “thank you” either.

You’ll want to know: nihil est — “it’s nothing”

Nihil est = literally “[it] **is nothing**” — **nihil** (“nothing”) + **est** (“is”). This is the phrase modern conversational-Latin communities commonly reach for as “you’re welcome,” parallel to English “it’s nothing” or Spanish *de nada*.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Nihil itself is genuinely classical and richly attested, from an older *nihilum*, itself built from **ne-** (“not”) + **hīlum** (“a tiny thing, a trifle” — said to have originally meant “the eye of a bean,” though its own ultimate origin is uncertain). So “nothing” in Latin literally started life as “not [even] a tiny bit” — the same shape of story as French’s *pas* (“not,” originally “a step”) or Spanish’s *nada* (from *nāta*, “a thing born”).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the careful part: **nihil** and **est** are both thoroughly classical, and *nihil est* itself appears in real Latin texts — but always meaning things like “there’s nothing to it” (“*nihil est, nūgae*”, “nothing, trifles,”

Plautus's *Bacchidēs*) or “that’s nothing” (*“istuc quidem [edepol] nihil est”*, Plautus's *Miles Gloriosus*), **never** specifically attested as a reply **to thanks**. No surviving Roman text shows someone answering *grātiās agō* with *nihil est*. Treat it the way you already treated *quōmodo tē habēs?*: real Latin words, put to a genuinely useful modern job, but not a citation from a Roman play.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nihil est” — “it’s nothing,” Latin’s answer to “thank you”
- nihil’s own history — ne- + hīlum, “not a tiny bit”
- the honest caveat — real words, modern job, not an ancient citation

Before you move on

What does **nihil est** literally mean, and what job does it do here? (“[It] is **nothing**” — the reply to *grātiās agō*, “thank you.”) What does **nihil** itself literally break down into? (**ne-** “not” + **hīlum** “a tiny thing” — “not a tiny bit.”) Is *nihil est* specifically attested in a classical text as a reply to thanks? (**No** — a modern conversational-Latin convention built from real words, not an ancient citation.)

Chapter 24

See You Soon

24.1 propediem tē vidēbō — a real change of pace: solidly attested, twice

The last few lessons were honest about real gaps — no fixed “how are you,” no fixed “nice to meet you,” no fixed “you’re welcome.” This one is different: a genuine, repeated Ciceronian phrase.

You’ll want to know: propediem tē vidēbō — “I shall see you soon”

Propediem tē vidēbō — “I shall see you soon” — is genuinely attested, not once but **twice**, in **Cicero’s** own letters:

- **Ad Familiārēs 2.12** (to Caelius): “*Sed, ut spērō, propediem tē vidēbō*” — “**But, as I hope, I shall see you soon.**”
- **Ad Familiārēs 15.6** (to Cato): “*Ego, ut spērō, tē propediem vidēbō*” — the same phrase, word order reshuffled, “**I, as I hope, shall see you soon.**”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Propediem breaks down as **prope** (“**near**”) + **diem** (accusative of **diēs**, “**day**”) — literally “**near the day**,” meaning “very soon, shortly.” That’s the **same diēs** from your days-of-week lessons (*diēs Lūnae*, *diēs Veneris*) — a familiar root showing up in a brand-new job.

Grammar Lens: vidēbō — the verb ending doing the work, again

Vidēbō is the **future tense** of **vidēre**, “to see” — and just like *agō* back in “thank you,” the **-bō** ending already carries “**I will**,” so no separate pronoun for “I” is needed. *Tē* (“you”) is simply the direct object: “[I] will-see you.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “propediem tē vidēbō” — “I shall see you soon”
- propediem’s own pieces — *prope* (near) + *diem* (the day)
- the honest contrast — unlike the last few lessons, this phrase IS solidly attested, twice, in Cicero

Before you move on

Where is **propediem tē vidēbō** genuinely attested, and how many times? (**Twice**, in **Cicero**’s letters — *Ad Familiārēs* 2.12 and 15.6.) What does **propediem** literally break down into? (**Prope** “near” + **diem** “the day” — the same *diēs* from the days-of-week lessons.) Does *vidēbō* need a separate word for “I”? (**No** — the *-bō* future ending already carries it, the same way *agō*’s *-ō* did.)

Chapter 25

See You Tomorrow

25.1 crās tē vidēbō — the same pattern, honestly not the same citation

Last lesson’s phrase was a direct quote from Cicero. This one uses the exact same grammatical machinery — but be honest: it isn’t itself pulled from a surviving letter.

You’ll want to know: crās tē vidēbō — built from known-good pieces

Crās tē vidēbō — “I’ll see you tomorrow” — swaps **crās** (“tomorrow”) in for *propediem* (“soon”) from the last lesson, keeping the same **vidēbō** (“I will see”) you already learned. Both pieces are genuinely classical: *crās* is a real, common Latin adverb, and *vidēbō* is the same attested future-tense verb as before. But be careful: unlike *propediem tē vidēbō*, this **specific combination** isn’t itself quoted in any surviving Roman letter — it’s a well-formed construction built by analogy, not a direct citation.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Crās traces back to **Proto-Italic** **krās* — but past that point, its ultimate origin is genuinely **uncertain**, with scholars proposing several different, competing Proto-Indo-European sources. Some things in etymology just don’t resolve cleanly, even for a word this ordinary.

Why it's said this way

Here's the real teaching point: **crās** didn't survive as the everyday word for "tomorrow" in most of its major daughter languages. **French's** *de-main*, **Italian's** *domani*, and **Catalan's** *demà* all rebuilt "tomorrow" from **dē māne** ("in the morning") instead — the same morning-based logic reappearing three separate times. **Sardinian** and **Sicilian** are the main holdouts that kept *crās* itself as an everyday word. Spanish, too, moved away from it, building its own *mañana* on **māne** ("morning") rather than keeping *crās*. A genuinely ordinary Latin word, abandoned by most of the family — echoing, if less completely, the same shape of story as *flāvus* from the colors lesson (which survives nowhere as an everyday word, only in names like *Flāvius*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "crās tē vidēbō" — "I'll see you tomorrow"
- the honest caveat — same pattern as *propediem tē vidēbō*, but not itself a direct quotation
- the Romance twist — nearly everyone replaced *crās* with a morning-based word instead

Before you move on

Is **crās tē vidēbō** itself quoted in a surviving Cicero letter, the way *propediem tē vidēbō* was? (**No** — same grammatical pattern, built from two genuinely classical pieces, but not itself a direct citation.) Which Romance language kept **crās** as its everyday word for "tomorrow"? (**Sardinian and Sicilian** — most of the rest rebuilt it from *dē māne*, "in the morning," instead.)

Chapter 26

How

26.1 *quōmodo* — the real word behind “how,” in three Romance languages at once

You’ve already met *quōmodo* once, as part of a phrase that turned out **not** to be classically attested. This lesson is honest about the flip side: the **word itself** is completely genuine.

You’ll want to know: *quōmodo* — genuinely classical, “by what manner”

Quōmodo (“**how, in what way**”) is a real, common Classical Latin word — a fusion of **quō** (ablative of *quis/quid*, “what”) + **modō** (ablative of *modus*, “manner, measure”), literally “**by what manner**.” It’s attested in both **Cicero** (*Dē Inventiōe*) and **Seneca** (*Epistulae Mōrālēs*) — genuinely classical, unlike the specific *quōmodo tē habēs?* greeting from Chapter 19, which was a modern construction. The **word** is real; it was only that one **exact phrase** that wasn’t.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Quōmodo is the **direct source** of Italian’s **come** and Spanish’s **cómo** — both simply continue *quōmodo*, worn down by ordinary sound change.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Here’s the honest surprise: French’s **comment** is **not** a simple continuation of *quōmodo* the way Italian and Spanish’s words are. French’s **comme** (“how, as, like”) continues *quōmodo* just like Italian’s *come*

does — but then **comment** picks up French’s own **-ment** adverb ending on top of that, from **mente** (ablative of *mēns*, “mind”) — the **same** *-ment* that turns any adjective into an adverb (*rapide* → *rapidement*, “quickly”). One well-attested account of this history holds that *comment* therefore marks “manner” **twice** — once via *quōmodo*’s own *modō*, once via *-ment*’s *mente* — where Italian and Spanish mark it only once, though the exact historical steps have more than one scholarly account.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quōmodo” — “how,” genuinely classical
- quō (what) + modō (manner) — “by what manner”
- the honest surprise — French’s *comment* double-marks “manner”; Italian/Spanish’s *come/cómo* mark it once

Before you move on

Is **quōmodo** itself genuinely classical, even though the specific phrase *quōmodo tē habēs?* wasn’t? (**Yes** — the word is real, attested in Cicero and Seneca; only that one specific greeting was modern.) What are *quōmodo*’s two Latin pieces, and what do they mean? (**Quō** “what” + **modō** “manner” — “by what manner.”) Is French’s **comment** a simple continuation of *quōmodo*, the way Italian’s *come* is? (**No** — it adds a second “manner” marker, *mente*, doubling up where Italian/Spanish only carry the sense once.)

Chapter 27

Well

27.1 bene — a morphologically simple inheritance

Last lesson’s “how” took a roundabout path into Romance, picking up an extra piece along the way. This one is refreshingly simple: one Latin word, one regular sound change, nothing grafted on.

You’ll want to know: bene — “well,” related to bonus

Bene (“well”) is a genuine Classical Latin adverb, closely related to **bonus** (“good”) — both descend from the same **Old Latin** ancestor, **duenos/duonus** (found in the famous **Duenos inscription**, one of the oldest surviving Latin texts). Past that point, the ultimate Proto-Indo-European root is debated, with more than one proposal on the table.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Here’s the refreshing part: French’s **bien** and Spanish’s **bien** both continue **bene** through **one single, regular sound change** — short stressed *e* diphthongizing to “**ie**,” the exact same shift behind *mel* → *miel* and *terra* → *tierra/terre* — and **nothing else**. No extra suffix gets grafted on, unlike *quōmodo*’s roundabout, multi-step journey into *come/cómo/comment*. When two Romance languages agree this closely, picking up only one shared, ordinary sound change between them, you’re looking almost straight at the Latin parent itself.

Why it's said this way

Bene is attested being used **alone**, repeated, in Plautus's **Stichus**, line 709 — though be honest about the context: it's a **drinking toast**, not literally an answer to “how are you.” The characters raise their cups and say: “**bene vōs, bene nōs, bene tē, bene mē, bene nostram etiam Stephanium**” — “**well to you, well to us, well to you, well to me, well to our Stephanium too.**” A real, attested use of *bene* standing alone — just repurposed here for the same conversational slot “well” fills, the way *volup est convēnisse* was for “nice to meet you.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bene” — “well,” related to bonus
- the morphologically simple inheritance — French/Spanish *bien* is *bene* plus one regular sound change, nothing grafted on
- the honest context — *bene vōs, bene nōs...* is a drinking toast in Plautus, not literally “how are you”

Before you move on

What Latin word is French and Spanish's **bien**, continued through one regular sound change? (**Bene**, “well.”) Is *quōmodo*'s path into Romance as morphologically simple as *bene*'s? (**No** — *quōmodo* picked up an extra grafted-on suffix along the way; *bene* → *bien* picked up only one ordinary sound change and nothing more.) Where is *bene* genuinely attested standing alone, and in what context? (**Plautus's Stichus, around line 708-709** — a drinking toast, not an answer to “how are you.”)

Chapter 28

Day

28.1 *diēs* — the word you already know, now standing alone

You’ve used this word twice already without a lesson of its own — inside *diēs Lūnae* and *medius diēs*. Time to meet it directly.

You’ll want to know: *diēs* — “day”

Diēs — “day” — is a genuinely common, everyday Classical Latin word, not a rare or bookish one. You’ve already met it embedded in:

- *diēs Lūnae* (“Monday,” literally “day of the Moon” — Chapter 5)
- *medius diēs* (“noon,” literally “mid-day” — Chapter 12)

Now it’s the headword itself.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Diēs has its own derivative, **diurnum** (“daytime, daily”), which gives English **diurnal** directly — and, through French’s *jour*, *journée*, and *jornel* (all descendants of *diurnum* in their own right), **journal** and **journey** as well (a “journey” was originally “a **day**’s travel”). **Diary** takes a **separate** path: it comes from a **sibling** derivative of *diēs*, **diārium** (“daily allowance”), not from *diurnum* itself — two related but distinct branches off the same root. Further out, a genuine **Proto-Indo-European** root, ***dyēws-** (“to shine, sky”), connects *diēs* to Latin’s own **deus** (“god”) and to **Iuppiter** (Jupiter, literally “sky-father”) — the same root that shines through the sky-god imagery of gods across the

Indo-European world.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “diēs” — “day”
- where you’ve already met it — diēs Lūnae, medius diēs
- the English cousins — diurnal, diary, journal, journey

Before you move on

Where have you already met **diēs** twice before this lesson? (**Diēs Lūnae**, “Monday”; **medius diēs**, “noon.”) What English word comes from diēs’s derivative *diurnum* directly? (**Diurnal**.) What two words come through French descendants of *diurnum* — *jour*, *journée*, *jornel*? (**Journal**, **journey**.) Does **diary** also come from *diurnum*? (**No** — a separate sibling derivative, *diārium*, “daily allowance.”)

Chapter 29

Night

29.1 *nox* — English’s own word, wearing a Roman toga

Last lesson gave *diēs* its own moment. Here’s its partner from *media nox* — and this time, the English cousin isn’t hiding behind centuries of sound change. It’s staring you in the face.

You’ll want to know: *nox* — “night”

Nox (genitive **noctis**) — “**night**” — is the word you’ve already met inside **media nox** (“midnight,” Chapter 12).

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Trace *nox* back far enough and you land on **Proto-Indo-European **nókʷts*** — and this is about as solid a reconstruction as historical linguistics gets. The cognates read almost like the same word spelled differently across a dozen languages: English’s own **night**, German **Nacht**, Greek **nyx**, Sanskrit **nakta**, Old Norse **nátt**, Gothic **nahts**. *Nox* and “night” aren’t just related — they’re about as close to being the same word as two languages 6,000 years apart can get.

Grammar Lens: The same suffix as *diurnum*, and a name for equal nights

Nox’s own derivative, **nocturnus** (“of the night”), wasn’t built from scratch — it was coined **directly on the analogy** of *diēs*’s own **diurnum**, reusing its exact *-urnus* suffix on purpose: the same suffix-

machine, deliberately applied to a second time-word. *Nocturnus* gives English **nocturnal** and **nocturne** directly. And **aequus** (“equal”) + *nox*’s stem *noct-* gives **equinox** — literally “**equal night**,” the day when day and night balance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nox” — “night,” genitive *noctis*
- the tight cousin — *nox*/night, nearly the same word
- *nocturnus*’s shared suffix with *diurnum* — the same -urnus pattern, two different times of day

Before you move on

Where have you already met **nox** before this lesson? (**Media nox**, “midnight.”) What English word is *nox* almost identical to, both descending from PIE **nókʷts*? (**Night**.) What suffix does *nocturnus* share with *diēs*’s *diurnum*? (**-urnus**.) What does *aequus* + *nox* give in English? (**Equinox**, “equal night.”)

Chapter 30

Good Night

30.1 bonam noctem — real grammar, not a real citation

You already have *bonus* (good) and *nox* (night, last lesson). Put them together for “good night” — but the case they end up in is the real lesson here.

Grammar Lens: bonam noctem — why accusative, not nominative

Bonam noctem = “good night” — but notice: **not** *bona nox* (nominative). Latin wishes and exclamations conventionally use the **accusative** case — the same “**Accusative of Exclamation**” behind the genuinely attested *Fēlicem nātālem!* (“happy birthday!” short for *tibi fēlicem diem nātālem exoptō*, “I wish you a happy birthday”). Grammatically, *bonam noctem* is a compressed exclamation — something like “[**I wish you**] a good night,” with the verb left unstated, the same kind of ellipsis you’d find in a letter opening like “*Cicero Atticō salutem [dīcit]*” (“Cicero sends greetings to Atticus”). The bare nominative *bona nox* would work too (with an implied “*sit*,” “may it be”), but the accusative is the more natural, idiomatic choice for a wish like this.

Grammar Lens: Be honest: real grammar, not a real citation

Here’s the careful part, matching the same honesty already applied to *quōmodo tē habēs?*, *nihil est*, and *crās tē vidēbō* earlier in this arc: the **accusative-of-wishing** principle itself is genuine, solid Classical Latin grammar. But this **specific fixed phrase**, *bonam noctem*, is **not** ac-

tually attested as a Roman farewell formula in any surviving classical text — it appears to be a later, post-classical convention, built correctly from real grammar but not itself a citation. Treat the grammar as reliable and the exact phrase as a well-formed construction, not a quotation from a Roman text.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bonam noctem” — “good night,” accusative
- the case rule — Latin wishes take the accusative, not the nominative
bona nox
- the honest caveat — solid grammar, but not itself an attested ancient farewell

Before you move on

Why is it **bonam noctem** and not **bona nox**? (**Latin wishes/exclamations conventionally take the accusative case**, not the nominative.) Is the accusative-of-wishing rule itself solid Classical Latin grammar? (**Yes.**) Is *bonam noctem* as one specific fixed phrase directly attested as a Roman farewell in any surviving classical text? (**No** — the grammar is real, but this exact phrase appears to be a later, post-classical convention.)

Chapter 31

Morning

31.1 *māne* — the word already hiding inside “tomorrow,” in four languages

You’ve already met this word once, without a lesson of its own — buried inside the very phrase that replaced *crās* across half the Romance family. Time to meet it directly.

Grammar Lens: *māne* — “morning,” an indeclinable word

Māne — “**morning, early**” — is an **indeclinable** neuter noun (and adverb): unlike *diēs* or *nox*, it never changes its ending, no matter its grammatical role. You’ve already met it once, inside **dē māne** (“in the morning,” Chapter 25) — the exact phrase that **French’s** *demain*, **Italian’s** *domani*, and **Catalan’s** *demà* all independently rebuilt as their new word for “tomorrow,” abandoning *crās*. **Spanish’s** *mañana* took a related but distinct path: built directly on **māne** itself, without the *dē-* (Vulgar Latin **maneāna*) — the same root, one step closer to the source.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Māne traces to **mānus**, an archaic Latin adjective meaning “**good**.” Watch the vowel length carefully: this is a **completely different** word from the everyday **manus** (“**hand**,” short *a*) — same spelling once macrons are dropped, unrelated meaning, a genuine false friend. From that “good” root comes **mātūrus** (“**ripe, timely, early**”), the direct source of English **mature** — and **mātūtīnus** (“of the morning,” tied to **Matūta**, the Roman goddess of dawn), which gives English, via Old

French *matines/matin*, both **matins** (“morning prayers”) and **matinee** (“afternoon performance”) — the same root splitting into two very different senses of “a scheduled morning-adjacent thing.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “māne” — “morning,” already met inside *dē māne*
- the false-friend warning — *mānus* “good” (long ā) vs. *manus* “hand” (short a)
- the English cousins — mature, matins, matinee, all from the same root as *māne*

Before you move on

Where did you already meet **māne** before this lesson? (Inside **dē māne**, “in the morning,” Chapter 25 — source of French *demain*, Italian *domani*, and Catalan *demà*.) Did Spanish *mañana* come from *dē māne* too? (**Not quite** — it was built directly on *māne* alone, without the *dē*-.) Is *māne*’s root *mānus* the same word as *manus*, “hand”? (**No** — a false friend; *mānus* “good” has a long ā, *manus* “hand” a short a.) What two very different English words both trace to *māne*’s “good” root, via *mātūtīnus*? (**Matins** and **matinee**.)

Chapter 32

Good Morning

32.1 bonum m̄ane — a phrase Romans didn’t say, and a ritual they actually did

You have *bonus* (good) and *m̄ane* (morning, last lesson). Put them together for “good morning” — but this time, watch for what’s **missing**, not just what’s uncertain.

Why it’s said this way

Bonum m̄ane = “**good morning**.” Like *bonam noctem* two lessons ago, this specific phrase is **not** classically attested as a fixed Roman greeting. But here the honesty runs one level deeper: *bonam noctem* showed you real, solid grammar — the accusative *noctem*, distinct from nominative *nox*, demonstrating Latin’s genuine “Accusative of Exclamation.” **M̄ane**, though, is **neuter** and **indeclinable** — and Latin neuter nouns **never** distinguish nominative from accusative, in any word, ever. *Bonum* works identically whether you imagine it as nominative or accusative. The grammar point that made *bonam noctem* interesting simply **isn’t visible** here — not because it’s missing, but because neuter words never show it, for anyone, anywhere in Latin.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s what Romans **did** have, richly documented: the **salūtātiō** (*mātūtīna salūtātiō*, “morning greeting”) — clients arriving at their patron’s house at **dawn**, formally dressed, to pay respects, ask favors, and sometimes receive the *sportula* (a small cash or food allowance) in return. It structured the start of the Roman day the way a verbal

“good morning” structures yours — just as a **ritual visit**, not a **spoken phrase**.

Salūtātiō comes from **salūtāre** (“to greet”), which comes from **salūs** (“health, safety, wholeness”) — and *salūs* is a genuine **doublet** of **salvus** (“safe, sound”), the very root behind **salvē** (Chapter 1’s first word, “hello,” literally “be well”). Both *salūs* and *salvus* descend from the same **Proto-Indo-European** root, **solh₂-* (“whole”). So Rome’s real morning greeting and its very first “hello” share one root, arrived at by two separate paths — a wish for someone’s wholeness, whether spoken as *salvē* or enacted at dawn as the *salūtātiō*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bonum māne” — “good morning,” a modern phrase, not classical
- why its grammar is invisible — māne is neuter, and neuters never show nominative vs. accusative
- “salūtātiō” — the real Roman morning greeting, a dawn visit, not a phrase — from the same root as *salvē*

Before you move on

Does *bonum māne* show the same accusative-of-wishing grammar that *bonam noctem* did? (**No** — māne is neuter, and Latin neuters never distinguish nominative from accusative, so the case is invisible either way.) What was Rome’s real, richly documented “morning greeting”? (The **salūtātiō** — clients visiting a patron’s house at dawn.) What word, already taught in Chapter 1, shares its root with *salūtātiō*? (**Salvē** — both *salūs* and *salvus* descend from the same PIE root, **solh₂-*, “whole.”)

Chapter 33

Evening

33.1 vesper — the evening word its own daughters mostly abandoned

A genuinely ordinary Latin word for “evening” — and a root that quietly reaches all the way to the English word *west*.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Vesper (also **vespera**) — “**evening**” — is a genuine, ordinary Classical Latin word, not a rare or poetic one: **vespere** (“in the evening”) shows up routinely in Cicero’s own letters. It traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **wekero-* (“evening, night”), itself an enlarged form of a root **we-*, which some reconstructions gloss as “down” (the direction the sun sets) — though this specific piece is more contested than the vesper/west link itself. That same conceptual root, through a completely separate **Germanic** branch, gives English its own word for “**west**” — evening and west, sharing one deep idea: the direction the sun goes down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vesper” — “evening,” genuinely everyday Classical Latin
- the deep root — *wekero-*, shared with English “west,” the direction of sunset
- the careful hedge — a lower root meaning “down” is more contested

Before you move on

What English word shares vesper's deep PIE root, and what's the connecting idea? (**West** — both trace to the direction the sun sets.) Is the proposed still-deeper root meaning “down” equally secure? (**No** — **that sub-root is more contested than the vesper/west link.**)

33.2 Hesperia, víspera, vespers — the root after Latin

Latin **vesper** and English **west** share the sunset idea. Now follow the evening root through Greek, English, Spanish, French, and Italian.

You'll want to know: Greek hesperos

The Greek cognate **hesperos** gives English **Hesperus**, the evening star (Venus at dusk), and **Hesperia**, “land of the west.” The name is relative: Greeks used it for Italy, west of Greece; Romans could use it for Spain, west of Italy.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

English borrowed **vespers**, the evening prayer service, and **vespertine**, “of the evening,” directly from Latin.

Spanish inherited *vespera* as **víspera**, but narrowed its meaning to “the eve” or “the day before” an event. French **soir** and Italian **sera** do not descend from **vesper** at all. They rebuilt “evening” from Latin **sērus**, “late,” through the idea of the “late day.”

One ordinary Latin word therefore leaves three different outcomes: a learned English loan, a narrowed Spanish descendant, and replacement by a different root in French and Italian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hesperia” — land of the west
- “víspera” — the eve or day before, narrowed from evening

- “soir, sera” — from *sērus*, “late,” not from *vesper*

Before you move on

What is Hesperus? (**The evening star.**) What does Spanish **víspera** mean now? (**The eve or day before an event.**) Which Latin root supplies French **soir** and Italian **sera**? (*Sērus*, “late.”) Name one direct English borrowing from **vesper**. (**Vespers** or **vespertine**.)

33.3 Practice — sort the evening words, then read the Latin

Be honest about what this chapter can give you. There is no Roman “good evening” yet — that arrives next chapter, and even then it is modern. What you can do **today** is triage: hear any European evening word and place it in the right family.

You’ll want to know: the two families, and the test that separates them

Everything in this chapter falls into exactly two lines, and one question separates them: **does the word still carry a *v* or an *h* from the sunset root, or does it come from “late”?**

- **Sunset family** — from *vesper*, or its Greek cousin *hesperos*: *vespers*, *vespertine*, *víspera*, *Hesperus*, *Hesperia*.
- **Late family** — from *sērus*, “late”: French *soir*, Italian *sera*.

Two traps worth naming. **Víspera** is in the sunset family but no longer means “evening” — it narrowed to “the eve, the day before.” And *soir* and *sera* look like the closest heirs of all, being the everyday words in Latin’s two nearest daughters, yet they are the ones that are **not** descended from *vesper* at all.

Your turn

- *Sort*: *vespers*, *sera*, *Hesperus*, *soir*, *víspera* → sunset or late

- *Say it:* the noun — **vesper**; and “in the evening” — **vespere**, the form Cicero uses in his letters
- *Say it:* the deep link that started it — *vesper* and English **west**, one idea: where the sun goes down

Before you move on

Sort these three without looking: **vespertine**, **sera**, **Hesperia**. (Sunset, late, sunset.) What does *vispera* mean in Spanish now? (**The eve, the day before** — narrowed, not lost.) And which everyday Latin form means “in the evening”? (**Vespere**.)

Chapter 34

Good Evening

34.1 bonum vesperum — the accusative rule returns, this time visibly

Two lessons ago, *bonum māne* couldn't show you Latin's real wish-grammar, because *māne* is neuter. This time it's back — because *vesper* isn't.

Grammar Lens: bonum vesperum — masculine, and the case shows again

Bonum vesperum = “good evening.” Like *bonam noctem* and *bonum māne*, this specific phrase is **not** classically attested as a fixed Roman greeting — the same honest gap, a third time. But the grammar here is different from *bonum māne*'s: **vesper** is **masculine**, and Latin masculine nouns genuinely **do** distinguish nominative (*vesper*) from accusative (*vesperum*) — unlike neuter *māne*, where the two forms were always identical. So *bonum vesperum* **does** demonstrate the real Accusative-of-Exclamation rule again, the same wish-construction behind *bonam noctem* and the genuinely attested *Fēlicem nātālem!* — just dressed in masculine endings instead of feminine ones.

Grammar Lens: A feminine alternate: bonam vesperam

Latin also has a separate **feminine** noun for evening, **vespera** (distinct from masculine *vesper*, though built from the same root — both headwords appeared together last lesson, though without their genders spelled out). Paired with *bonus*, its accusative gives **bonam vesperam** — agreeing the **same way** *bonam noctem* does: the adjective, *bonam*,

matches *bonam* exactly. But watch the **nouns** carefully — they do **not** share an ending. *Vespera* is **1st declension** (accusative *-am*, *vesperam*), while *nox* is **3rd declension** (accusative *-em*, *noctem* — **not** *-am*). Same adjective agreement, genuinely different noun declensions underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*bonum vesperum*” — “good evening,” masculine accusative
- why this one shows the case rule, unlike *bonum māne* — *vesper* is masculine, not neuter
- “*bonam vesperam*” — the feminine alternate, matching *bonam noctem*’s own shape

Before you move on

Is *bonum vesperum* itself directly attested as a classical Roman greeting? (**No** — a modern, pedagogical phrase, like *bonam noctem* and *bonum māne*.) Why does *bonum vesperum* show the real Accusative-of-Exclamation rule, when *bonum māne* couldn’t? (**Vesper** is **masculine**, and masculine nouns distinguish nominative from accusative; *māne* is neuter, where the two are always identical.) What’s the feminine alternate, and how does its adjective agreement compare to *bonam noctem*’s? (**Bonam vesperam** — the adjective *bonam* matches *bonam* exactly, but the NOUNS don’t share an ending: *vesperam* is 1st declension *-am*, while *noctem* is 3rd declension *-em*, not *-am*.)

Chapter 35

Noon and Afternoon

35.1 merīdiēs — the word you already know, one sound-change later

You already have *medius diēs*. Rome had no separate word for “afternoon”; it split the whole day around this word.

Sounds you’ll need

Merīdiēs — “**midday, noon**” — is the **same phrase** as **medius diēs** (Chapter 12), just **contracted**: an earlier *medīdiēs* dropped its repeated *d*-sound (dissimilation) to become *merīdiēs*, a fifth-declension noun in its own right (accusative *merīdiem*). It’s the ultimate root of English **meridian**, via the Latin adjective **merīdiānus** (“of midday”).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the twist: Spanish has *tarde*, French has *après-midi*, German has *Nachmittag* — a single word naming “the afternoon” as its own block of time. **Latin doesn’t**. Instead, Romans split the **entire day** around *merīdiēs* into two large halves: **ante merīdiem** (“**before noon**”) and **post merīdiem** (“**after noon**”) — the direct ancestors of English’s own **a.m.** and **p.m.**, used on every clock and phone today, often without anyone realizing they’re speaking Latin.

This wasn’t just a loose figure of speech — it carried real legal weight. Under the **Twelve Tables**, Rome’s foundational law code, a civil case had to be argued **before noon**, with both parties present; if one party failed to appear, the magistrate could rule **against them, in absentia, once it passed noon**. *Ante* and *post merīdiem* divided not just clock

time, but courtroom procedure.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

You’ve already met *tardus* (“slow, late”) through Spanish’s own *tarde* — the very word Spanish reshaped into its “afternoon.” In Latin itself, *tardus* never made that leap: it stayed a plain adjective, “slow, late,” and never became a Latin noun for “afternoon.” Spanish’s shift from “late” to “the afternoon” happened entirely on its own, after Latin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “merīdiēs” — the same *medius diēs*, contracted
- “ante merīdiem,” “post merīdiem” — before/after noon, the source of a.m./p.m.
- the honest twist — no separate Latin word for “afternoon,” just a line drawn at noon

Before you move on

What earlier phrase is *merīdiēs* a contracted form of? (*Medius diēs*, Chapter 12.) What two English abbreviations, used on every clock, come directly from *ante merīdiem* and *post merīdiem*? (**a.m.** and **p.m.**.) Did this noon-based division matter beyond just telling time? (**Yes** — under the Twelve Tables, Roman court cases had a real legal deadline at noon.) Does Latin have its own separate word for “afternoon,” the way Spanish has *tarde*? (**No** — Romans split the whole day around *merīdiēs* instead.)

Chapter 36

Good Afternoon

36.1 *salvē* (post merīdiem) — the one that isn’t there

Three lessons in a row, you’ve met a modern phrase built on real (if sometimes invisible) Latin grammar for “good ____.” This lesson is different: there’s honestly nothing to build.

Why it’s said this way

Bonam noctem, **bonum mātē**, and **bonum vesperum** are all modern, pedagogical phrases — not classically attested — but each pairs *bonus* directly with a **single noun** in the accusative: *noctem*, *mātē*, *vesperum*. “Good afternoon” can’t take that same shape, because you already learned last lesson that Latin has **no simplex noun** for “afternoon” at all — there’s no *afternoonem* for *bonus* to modify. **Bonum post merīdiem** doesn’t work: *post merīdiem* (“after noon”) is a whole **prepositional phrase**, not a noun, so *bonus* has nothing to agree with. A three-word workaround, **bonum tempus pōmerīdiānum** (“good afternoon time”), actually **is** grammatical — *pōmerīdiānus* (“of the afternoon”) is a real word Cicero himself uses, and here *bonus* agrees with a genuine noun, *tempus* (“time”). But it’s a **periphrasis**, not a direct two-word match for the other three phrases — and it isn’t itself attested anywhere as something Romans actually said as a greeting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- why “*bonum post merīdiem*” doesn’t work — no noun for *bonus* to agree with; why “*bonum tempus pōmerīdiānum*” DOES work, but isn’t attested as a real greeting
- the grammatical adjective — *pōmerīdiānum*, “of the afternoon”

Before you move on

Does Latin have a two-word phrase for “good afternoon” the way it has *bonum vesperum* for evening? (**No** — Latin has no simplex noun for “afternoon” for *bonus* to pair with.) Is there ANY grammatical Latin phrase at all? (**Yes** — *bonum tempus pōmerīdiānum* is real grammar, but a three-word periphrasis, not attested as an actual greeting.) What did Romans say in the afternoon instead? (**Salvē** — the same everyday greeting from Chapter 1.) Why doesn’t *bonum post merīdiem* work grammatically? (*Post merīdiem* is a whole prepositional phrase, not a single noun *bonus* can agree with.)

36.2 salvē — the greeting that does not watch the clock

Latin cannot build a neat two-word “good afternoon.” What did Romans actually need in that time slot? Nothing beyond a greeting you already know.

Why it’s said this way

Salvē to one person and **salvēte** to several people mean “be well.” Neither form contains a morning, afternoon, or evening boundary. Romans could use the greeting whenever they met someone.

English encourages a learner to search for four matched clock-based formulas. Latin everyday greetings do not divide the day that way. The missing afternoon formula is therefore not a hole in Roman conversation. The time-of-day arc now has three different kinds of evidence:

- a real institution, the morning **salūtātiō**
- grammatical but modern phrases such as **bonam noctem**
- no dedicated formula at all for afternoon—just **salvē**

Learning those differences is more faithful than forcing four symmetrical translations into Latin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “salvē” — be well, to one person
- “salvēte” — be well, to several people
- the time restriction — none

Before you move on

What can one Roman say on meeting another in the afternoon? (**Salvē.**) What is the plural? (**Salvēte.**) Do these words encode a time of day? (**No.**) Why is there no conversational gap? (**The everyday greeting already works whenever people meet.**)

36.3 Practice — one whole day, in the words you have

Nine chapters of time-of-day words end here. This is the one place they all have to work at once — four meetings, one day, and no inventing.

The exchange — morning to night, with the honest label on each line

Morning. A: Salvē! Quid agis? B: Valeō. Salvē!

Afternoon. A: Salvē! B: Salvē!

Evening. A: Bonum vesperum! B: Salvē!

Parting at night. A: Bonam noctem! B: Valē!

Now the label, which is half the payoff. **Salvē**, **salvēte** and **valē** are genuinely Roman and carry no clock inside them, so they work in every one of those four rows. The three *bonus* phrases — *bonum māne*, *bonum*

vesperum, *bonam noctem* — are well-formed modern teaching phrases, not lines from any surviving Roman text. And the afternoon row has only *salvē* in it, because Latin never had a noun for “afternoon” for *bonus* to agree with.

So the safe rule you leave with: **when in doubt, salvē on arrival and valē on departure, at any hour.**

Your turn

- *Run through:* all four rows aloud, both voices
- *Choose:* mid-afternoon, and you want to be Roman → **salvē**
- *Say it:* why it is *noctem* and *vesperum*, not *nox* and *vesper* — Latin wishes take the accusative
- *Choose:* a room full of people → **salvēte**

Before you move on

Which two words in the whole day-cycle are genuinely attested? (**Salvē** and **valē**.) What did Rome actually have in the morning instead of a phrase? (The **salūtātiō** — a dawn visit, an action.) Why can *bonum māne* not show the accusative rule? (*Māne* is **neuter**; neuters never distinguish the two cases.)

How Latin sounds — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach the sounds through real words. This page gathers the classical scheme in one place.

The three facts

1. **Every letter is sounded, always the same way.** Latin has no silent letters and (in the classical scheme) no “soft” consonants: *c* and *g* are *always* hard (*Cicero* = *KIH-keh-ro*, not “SIS-er-o”), *v* is **w**, *s* is always hissed (never “z”), and *r* is trilled.
2. **Vowels come long or short, marked by a macron.** *ā ē ī ō ū* are *held longer* than *a e i o u* — same quality, more time. Length could change meaning (*malum* “evil” vs. *mālum* “apple”), which is why teaching texts print the macrons Romans never wrote.
3. **Two vowels together each keep their value** unless they form a set diphthong: *ae* = “eye” (*Caesar* = *KYE-sar*), *au* = “ow,” *oe* = “oy.”

Worth flagging

- ***v* = w, *i* = y.** The consonantal *v* and *i* were glides: *vīnū*... said *WEE-noom* (*vīnum*, “wine”), *Iulius* = *YOO-lee-oos*. The “v as vee” and “soft c” you may have heard are *later*, Church-Latin habits.
- **Stress is predictable.** Two-syllable words stress the first; longer words stress the second-to-last syllable if it is long, else the one before. No accent marks needed once you hear vowel length.
- **No “j” or “w” or “u/v” split.** Classical Latin wrote *i* and *v* for both vowel and glide; the letters *j*, *u*, and *w* are medieval and modern additions.

Latin in the family

Latin is **Italic**, a branch of the great **Indo-European** family — cousin to Greek, to the Germanic languages (including English), and, further off, to Sanskrit. It was the speech of Rome, then of an empire, then of the medieval church and the learned world; as it fragmented in daily use it became Spanish, Portuguese, French, Italian, Romanian, and the rest. That is why this curriculum treats Latin as a *taproot*: nearly every word here has both English and Romance descendants, traced in the lessons.